



Russian-Speaking Immigrant Experiences of Emotional Labor at Work in the United States

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UNIVERSITY OF MIAMI

RUSSIAN-SPEAKING IMMIGRANT EXPERIENCES OF EMOTIONAL LABOR AT
WORK IN THE UNITED STATES

By

Alexandra Lane

A DISSERTATION

Submitted to the Faculty
of the University of Miami
in partial fulfillment of the requirements for
the degree of Doctor of Philosophy

Coral Gables, Florida

August 2021

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UNIVERSITY OF MIAMI

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Russian-Speaking Immigrant Experiences of
Emotional Labor at Work in the United States

(Ph.D., Counseling Psychology)
(August 2021)

Abstract of a dissertation at the University of Miami.

Dissertation supervised by Associate Professor Debbiesiu Lee.
No. of pages in text. (158)

This study sought to bridge the fields of acculturation psychology and industrial and organizational psychology through a phenomenological investigation of the emotional labor experiences of Russian-speaking immigrants working in the United States. This study explored emotional labor in an intercultural context, as participants immigrated as adults and needed to learn different emotional display rules from those of their heritage culture in order to perform their jobs. Interviews were conducted with 10 participants and the resulting data was analyzed using Hycner's (1999) five-step process of phenomenological analysis. Three overarching themes emerged from the horizon of *the recalibration of expectations of social control, trust, and emotional performance*: 1. Finding new individual freedoms alongside new social surveillance; 2. Figuring out who to trust; and 3. Maintaining appropriate emotions at work. These themes and subthemes were explained in detail in order to providing a thick description of the emotional labor experiences of participants. Findings of this study may better inform future avenues for research, practice, and policy regarding intercultural emotional labor and Russian-speaking immigrant workers.

Keywords: *emotional labor, acculturation, immigration, trust, social control*

DEDICATION

This dissertation is dedicated to my mom, whose unrelenting support makes everything possible.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Completing a Ph.D. challenged me in ways I never expected. I have learned so much about myself, my field, and the people around me. I want to express gratitude to those people, because without them none of this would be possible.

Thank you to my mother, who loves me and supports me in everything. Thank you to my father, who fed and housed me as I finished writing, and encouraged me to go outside sometimes. Thank you to Rishad Choudhury and Nidhi Mahajan, who read drafts of this project, listened to versions of my presentations about it, and helped me get through my own self-doubt. You guys are also a lot of fun. Thank you to Carter Higgins, who helped me recruit participants, and to Yasmine Singh, who provided much needed emotional support. Thank you to Lilla Balint, who pumped me up and made me feel golden when I needed it most. Thank you to Samantha Lang, who was a mentor and always told me I could do it. Thank you to Natalie Ramirez, who has been my angel for so many years. Thank you to Alex Kasavin, who helped me understand what it feels like to be Russian-American. Thank you to everyone who touched my life in ways that I might be too shy or too forgetful to mention.

Thank you to all of my generous participants, who shared their time and their stories.

Finally, thank you to Dina Birman, who cared about me and helped me see myself as a scholar.

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CHAPTER 1: Introduction

Emotions are intuitively felt as spontaneous products of an individual's experiences, but in truth they are shaped by larger cultural and economic forces. This project seeks to elucidate some of those forces, by examining how individuals negotiate the emotional demands of multiple cultures in employment settings. In service jobs, which comprise 80% of the US economy (Central Intelligence Agency, 2017), there is more at stake than the sale of a physical product; emotions must be managed in order to provide the customer with a desirable experience. The work of managing one's emotions in order to perform a job like this is called emotional labor (Hochschild, 1983).

This type of labor is increasingly occurring in a globalized context, in which people of diverse cultural backgrounds must communicate their feelings to each other. In the US, over one million people from all over the world become permanent residents every year (Department of Homeland Security, 2017). Most of these new residents end up employed in roles that entail emotional labor for an American clientele (Kosten, 2018; Hochschild, 1983). Yet little research has explored the experience of emotional labor in an intercultural context. Russian-speaking immigrants, in particular, display cultural traits, such as a high need for interpersonal trust (McCarthy & Puffer, 2003), and reserved public emotional display rules (Sheldon et al., 2017), that suggest they would have a distinctive experience of emotional labor in the U.S., where there is an emphasis on effusive displays of friendliness to strangers in work contexts (Kipnis, Schmidt & Wilkinson, 1980; Kuchinke, 1999).

The purpose of this study was to understand the experience of Russian-speaking immigrants performing emotional labor in U.S workplaces. In this project, the term

“culture” is defined using Barbara Rogoff’s (2003) theory of culture. Culture is the way people use language and other symbolic tools to participate in a community, with particular attention to “the configurations of routine ways of doing things in any community’s approach to living” (Rogoff, 2003, p.3). The cultural group of this study’s participants will thus be defined by their shared language, as Russian-speaking immigrants. Native Russian speakers are geographically dispersed across the nations of the Former Soviet Union (FSU), yet they share a common language that grants them access to Russian cultural traditions, routines, and practices. Thus, I will refer to the culture of this group as “Russian.”

Background

Most research on emotional labor comes from the field of industrial and organizational (I/O) psychology and has been conducted with homogeneous Western samples from the US and Europe (Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013). While contextual factors within organizations, such as workplace climate or management style, have been examined, researchers have rarely looked at broader cultural context. The few studies that do examine culture do so through the lens of national cultural identity (e.g. Germanic vs. Latin European), which collapses all workers in a given nation into a single monocultural group (see Hülshager & Schewe, 2011; Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013). This approach fails to examine how workers navigate multiple cultural contexts superimposed upon each other, as in the case of immigrants or bicultural individuals.

Emotional labor is comprised of surface acting, in which emotions are masked or faked, and deep acting, in which employees work to change their feelings in order create a more genuine performance (Grandey & Melloy, 2017). Emotion regulation and

management occurs constantly, in both public and private life, with others and alone, in order to alter mood and behavior (Hochschild, 2003; Gross, 1998). In contexts where a person is being paid for this emotion work, it can become alienating in the Marxist sense, as the person can start to feel isolated from the parts of the self that performs this labor (Hochschild, 1983).

Emotional labor has shown a robust causal relationship to feelings of burnout, consisting of emotional exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced job satisfaction (Maslach, Schaufeli, & Leitner, 2001). Surface acting in particular, sometimes conceptualized as discordant emotional labor, has been associated with a range of harmful consequences, including deterioration in both mental and physical health (Mesmer-Magnus, DeChurch, & Wax, 2012; Hülshager & Schewe, 2011; Kammeyer-Mueller et al., 2011). Deep acting, in contrast, is associated with greater role identification, higher job satisfaction, lower stress and exhaustion, and generally more positive work outcomes. The relationship between surface acting and negative outcomes may be particularly strong in US workplaces due to a cultural emphasis on friendliness, assertiveness, optimism, and enthusiasm as tactics for influencing customers and employees (Kipnis, Schmidt & Wilkinson, 1980; Kuchinke, 1999). These tactics involve high levels of emotional labor. In addition, US culture places a value on authenticity, which implies a conflict between this labor and an American worker's internalized understanding of how emotions are supposed to function. This has been found to increase stress on employees performing emotional labor in the US as compared to in other cultures (Allen, Diefendorff, & Ma, 2013; Grandey, Fisk, & Steiner, 2005).

It should be noted that many of the jobs with the highest emotional labor demands, such as nursing, teaching, serving, and childcare, are considered traditionally feminine (Hochschild, 2003). This suggests a conceptual link between gender and emotional labor experiences, and research has borne out this connection. Women are found to bear higher emotional labor burdens even when they share identical job roles with men (Cottingham, Erickson, & Diefendorff, 2015; Erickson, 2004; Gray, 2010; Meier, Mastracci, & Wilson, 2006; Polleta & Tufail, 2016; Simpson & Stroh, 2004), and women experience more negative outcomes from emotional labor (Johnson & Spector, 2007; Han et al., 2018; Wang, Huang, Yin, & Ke, 2018; Walsh & Bartikowski, 2013).

Workers who have migrated from one culture to another as adults have unique experiences that may influence the outcomes of emotional labor. Immigrants who cross from one culture into another undergo the process of acculturation, cultural change that occurs when individuals come into continuous first-hand contact with a new culture (Birman & Addae, 2015; Redfield, Linton, & Herskovits, 1936). Physical, psychological, and social distress associated with the acculturation process, known as acculturative stress (Berry, 1970), could influence their performance of emotional labor. In addition to acculturative stress, many immigrants struggle with underemployment, as they may not receive recognition for the skills, training, and education that they bring from their country of origin (Lane & Lee, 2018; Dean & Wilson, 2009). Immigrants from non-English speaking countries must often work in a second language, which can make emotional labor and emotion regulation especially challenging (Gust, Petermann, and Koglin, 2014; Williams, Srinivasan, Liu, Lee, & Zhou, 2019). In acquiring fluency in a second language, they must not only learn a new vocabulary and grammar, but also a

whole encyclopedia of background knowledge and local information embedded in the language and the specific situations in which it is used, referred to by anthropologist Michael Agar (2006) as a languaculture.

Immigrants who arrive as adults have been socialized into the emotional norms of their cultures of origin prior to arrival (Friedlmeier, Corapci & Cole, 2011). Thus, they may also need to more effortfully adjust their emotional patterns to conform to those of their newly adopted culture (De Leersnyder, 2017), which could produce enhanced dissonance for the emotional labor demands of their specific US workplace.

The lack of intercultural research on emotional labor has left emotional socialization and acculturation processes underexamined as complicating factors in the relationship between emotional labor and well-being. Emotional expression is socialized from an early age to fit within cultural models of desirable emotions and how to display them (Tsai, Louie, Chen, & Uchida, 2007; Matsumoto, 1990). Due to these differing emotional display rules and expectations, research has already demonstrated that emotion regulation mechanisms have distinct psychological impacts on different cultural groups (Butler et al., 2007). This suggests that an adult immigrant employee would have a qualitatively distinct experience of emotional labor.

Russian-speaking immigrants, in particular, suggest interesting contrasts to US nationals. While the US has been described as individualistic, emphasizing individual autonomy and the achievement of personal goals, Russian culture has been described as collectivistic, emphasizing interpersonal connection and the goals of the family over the individual (Khan & Panarina, 2017; Michailova & Hutchings, 2006). Russians have also been described as more emotionally reserved in public than Americans, whose common

practice of smiling at strangers can come across as baffling to newly arrived Russian-speaking immigrants (Christophel, 1996; Markowitz, 1993; Sternina & Sternin, 2003). These divergent tendencies suggest that Russian-speaking immigrants might be navigating multiple, conflicting rules of cultural participation when performing emotional labor in a US workplace.

Purpose of the study

The purpose of this phenomenological study is to explore and understand the task of emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants at work in the US. What is a Russian-speaking immigrant employee's experience of emotional labor? There has been extensive research on emotional labor and its effects on well-being and job satisfaction, yet the experience of performing emotional labor in intercultural contexts is still largely unknown. This study used a phenomenological approach, grounded in the subjectivity of individual human experience as it intersects with experiences shared in common. The study relied on data from semi-structured interviews (see Interview Guide in Appendix B) with adults who have immigrated to the US from the Soviet Union or one of the countries of the former Soviet Union, and are currently employed in positions that require frequent interaction with the public. Interviewing these individuals granted insight into how they experienced the emotional labor that their jobs entailed.

Since there was such a small body of research on how Russian-speaking immigrants in the US experience emotional labor, a quantitative design was deemed inappropriate, due to the constraints it would place on a relatively unknown and complex topic. Quantitative instruments would likely not have been normed on the population

under study. A qualitative design was chosen because it is capable of exploring the topic in depth to inform directions for future research.

Research questions

Research questions for phenomenology are based on problems for which “it is important to understand several individuals’ common or shared experiences of a phenomenon” (Creswell, 2013, p. 81). The research questions for this study were:

RQ1: How do Russian-speaking immigrants in the U.S. experience emotional labor in their U.S. work settings?

RQ2: How do cultural factors, including gender, affect this aspect of work life for Russian-speaking immigrants in the U.S.?

Significance of the study

Given the increasing presence of immigrants in service roles in the United States, it has become more important than ever to understand emotional labor in intercultural context, and how it contributes to immigrant employees’ job satisfaction and well-being. This topic affects millions of workers every day. This project will shed light on the topic, through the specific case of Russian-speaking immigrants, and possibly create avenues for future research into how to ameliorate workplaces for intercultural labor. This project also seeks to enrich insights from I/O psychology by using the lens of immigration and acculturation psychology to look at the cultural processes underlying emotional labor.

Limitations and delimitations

This study delimited itself to examining the experiences of Russian-speaking adult immigrant workers (over the age of 18), in order to specifically look at the impact of acculturation on the emotional labor experience. Sampling focused on examining the

experience of Russian-speaking immigrants, as this group has been observed to conform to emotional display rules that contrast notably with mainstream US culture. Russian-speaking immigrants possess unique historical circumstances that influence their cultural practices in ways that may impact their experience of emotional labor performance. As such, findings may be limited in their transferability to immigrant workers of other backgrounds.

In addition, there was a limitation in the specificity of this project's examination of the cultural factors unique to the many different groups and subgroups of Russian-speaking immigrants that exist. The study also attended to how the traditional gender binary impacts this process, thus only those who identify as men or women were included in the study. Transgender and nonbinary individuals were excluded from this study, which may limit the transferability of findings to gender non-conforming groups. The study focused on emotional labor performed in a work role, and consequently paid less attention to other aspects of emotion management performed in other life domains.

Summary

This study sought to understand how Russian-speaking immigrants perform emotional labor at work in the US. As most previous research on emotional labor has not focused on cultural factors or intercultural contexts influencing emotional perception, experience, and expression, there is a knowledge gap regarding how immigrants experience the emotional display requirements within their workplaces. The results of this study may aid Russian-speaking immigrants at work, those who work with them, and those who seek to facilitate their job satisfaction and well-being. Findings may also enrich I/O and vocational psychology more broadly by elucidating culture's impact on

emotional labor performance. Finally, clinical and counseling psychology may benefit from insights into this population as they strive to practice culturally competent care with Russian-speaking immigrants.

Four chapters follow. Chapter 2 is a comprehensive review of the literature on emotional labor and the literature on immigrant acculturation processes, including specific literature on Russian-speaking immigrants, with attention to how acculturation and adjustment impacts emotional life. The primary focus of Chapter 2 is bridging these distinct bodies of literature and exposing the gap therein where my project is situated. Chapter 3 discusses the methodology and research design of this project, as well as my positionality as a researcher. Chapter 4 describes the horizon, themes and subthemes uncovered through the data explication process. Chapter 5 discusses the conclusions of this study, including recommendations derived from the findings for future research, policy, and counseling practice with Russian-speaking immigrants.

CHAPTER 2: Literature Review

Overview

Emotional labor (EL) is defined by sociologist Arlie Hochschild as labor that “requires one to induce or suppress feeling in order to sustain the outward countenance that produces the proper state of mind in others” (Hochschild, 1983, p. 7). EL is the effort put forth by employees to express emotions acceptable to their workplace. Since its inception, EL has been the topic of hundreds of empirical studies. These studies can be divided into several groups: antecedents of EL, consequences of EL to the individual, and consequences of EL to the organization (Yanchus, Eby, Lance, & Drollinger, 2011).

The first part of this literature review will focus on the body of research that examines EL’s antecedents and consequences to the lives of workers, as well as identify factors that influence these causal relationships, and cross-cultural research examining EL outside of North America. The review will not focus on organizational outcomes of EL, such as productivity and customer satisfaction, as they are less relevant to the present study.

The second part of this literature review will delve into research on immigration and acculturation processes, highlighting findings that suggest that immigrants have distinct emotional experiences that would influence their relationship to EL. This influence is important to examine because emotional labor is culturally situated, and thus far research on this topic has not adequately examined intercultural contexts as a backdrop for the performance and experience of emotional labor. Immigrant employees are unique in their position as intercultural agents, navigating both the emotional

socialization they received in their country of origin, and the emotional expectations of their new cultural context, including their workplace and the broader society they inhabit.

The last part of this literature review will discuss research on Russian culture and the culture and history of Russian-speaking immigrants to the US. By examining the specific experience of Russian-speaking immigrants performing emotional labor, research can better understand the way culture impacts the emotional labor process in general, as well as highlight how to create more hospitable workplaces for Russian-speaking immigrants who currently perform emotional labor at work in the US.

Emotional Labor

Antecedents

Hochschild called the societal norms that govern the management of human emotion “feeling rules,” and defined them as “the social guidelines that direct how we want to try to feel” (1979, p. 563) through “establishing a sense of entitlement or obligation that governs emotional exchanges” (1983, p.56). These rules are held implicitly and in common with other participants of a given culture. Organizations possess their own norms of emotional expression, nested within and generally consistent with the norms of the society in which they operate (Ashforth & Humphrey, 1993). In this context, the rules of emotional display are called *display rules*, because they govern the externally observable expression of feeling without reference to what might be going on inside of the person making that display.

Display rules are often explicitly regulated by work organizations (Hochschild, 2003), yet even when they are merely inferred, they remain a powerful set of beliefs about emotional expression held in common by employees who work together

(Diefendorff, Erickson, Grandey, & Dahling, 2011). For example, a salesperson or waitstaff may be required to smile at every customer who enters the store or restaurant. These are examples of *positive display rules*, in that they are requirements placed on the expression of positive emotion (Trougakos, Jackson, & Beal, 2011). Positive display rules may require the suppression of positive emotions as well, for example in the case of someone working at a funeral home who may be required not to smile.

Positive display rules are only one facet of the display rules that an employee might experience. *Negative display rules* are requirements placed on negative emotional expressions (Trougakos et al., 2011). Certain professions (e.g. bill collecting and police work) require less friendly emotional displays, such as irritation, intimidation, or distrust (Hochschild, 2003; Martin, 1999). Negative display rules might also require the suppression of negative emotional displays, as in the case of customer service roles. A third kind of requirement is a *neutral display rule*, in which a suppression of both positive and negative emotional expressions is required (Grandey & Melloy, 2017; Trougakos et al., 2011). An extreme example of this type of display can be seen in Buckingham Palace guards who are required to be expressionless and unresponsive.

As one might expect, jobs with more display rules have been associated with higher levels of EL (Gosserand & Diefendorff, 2005). More frequent interactions with the public, and longer interactions, are also associated with greater EL (Morris & Feldman, 1996). Whenever emotional events occur at work, engendering either positive or negative affect in an employee, EL will be required to manage the resultant emotional display (Grandey, 2000). Roles that require a variety of emotional expressions are associated with higher levels of EL (Morris & Feldman, 1996). Neutral display rules are associated

with particularly high levels of EL, as they require suppression of the full range of emotional expression (Trougakos et al., 2011).

Research on US workplace culture has highlighted an emphasis on rational persuasion, friendliness, assertiveness, optimism, and enthusiasm as tactics for influencing customers and employees (Kipnis, Schmidt & Wilkinson, 1980; Kuchinke, 1999). All of these tactics involve emotional labor, suggesting that US workplaces may be notable for placing a heavier emotional labor burden on employees than workplaces in other cultures. In addition, research has found that US workplaces adhere to individualistic cultural values, in which employees are expected to act autonomously, derive status from individual accomplishments, and feel individual responsibility for results (Newman & Nollen, 1996). As such, US workplaces are often oriented towards activity and achievement, rather than thought and observation, and perceived failure can have high emotional stakes.

Hochschild's 1983 report listed the following jobs as "most calling for emotional labor": Lawyers and judges, librarians, registered nurses, dental hygienists, therapists, clergy, social workers, teachers and professors, vocational and educational counselors, public relations and publicity writers, radio and television announcers, physicians, dentists, labor relations personnel, bank tellers, cashiers, clerical supervisors, bill collectors, insurance adjusters, postal clerks, receptionists, ticket agents, bartenders, food service workers, childcare workers, hairdressers, housekeepers, ushers, and protective service workers (pp. 246-250). In thirty years of ensuing research, certain job roles have been repeatedly found to involve high levels of EL, such as hospitality (Chen et al., 2012), teaching (Näring, Briet, & Brouwers, 2006), restaurant service (Yagil & Medler-

Liraz, 2017), nursing (Yoon & Kim, 2013) and sales (Giardini & Frese, 2008). This list is not inclusive of newly emerging, flexible and temporary jobs in the modern gig economy, such as driving for Uber, or performing odd jobs on TaskRabbit, as this type of work is too recent to have been extensively studied (Friedman, 2014).

Strategies

Research has found that employees use two main strategies to perform emotional labor: surface acting and deep acting (Grandey & Melloy, 2017; Diefendorff, Croyle, & Gosserand, 2005; Hülshager, Lang, Schewe, & Zijlstra, 2015). These two components have found repeated empirical support (see Diefendorff, Croyle, & Gosserand, 2005; Chu & Murrman, 2006; Kiral, 2016).

Surface acting is faking an emotion with full awareness that one's inner feelings are different. It often involves the suppression of emotions contrary to those that need to be displayed (Simpson & Stroh, 2004). An example of this can be seen in a waiter or waitress smiling when he or she is privately annoyed at a customer's demands.

Deep acting involves attempting to genuinely feel the emotion required in the situation. This is accomplished through techniques such as reappraisal of the situation, and attentional deployment, in which, as in 'method acting,' events that triggered a particular emotional in the past reaction are recalled when that emotion is required in a new situation (Yanchus et al., 2010; Kuhn & Westwell, 2012). An example of this might be a waiter or waitress imagining that complaining customers are children, making it easier to summon empathy for them and to treat them gently.

Outcomes

Expressing emotions as a part of a work role has wide-reaching impacts on a person's life, both positive and negative. EL has effects on job involvement, job satisfaction, burnout, and emotional well-being (Zammuner, Lotto, & Galli, 2003; Schaubroeck & Jones, 2000). Consequences of EL have been found to vary by the type of EL employed (Grandey, 2000).

Faking or suppressing emotions on a regular basis is linked to a pattern of negative relationships with work outcome and stress (Kammeyer et al., 2013). Surface acting has been found to lead to the most negative outcomes for workers, such as burnout, emotional exhaustion, increase in negative affect and increased desire to quit (Yanchus et al., 2011; Brotheridge & Grandey, 2002; Brotheridge & Lee, 2003; Hur, Rhee, & Ahn, 2016). Deep acting can make an employee more attached to his or her job, by creating an emotional justification for its importance. In contrast to surface acting, deep acting is associated with greater role identification, higher job satisfaction, lower stress and exhaustion, and generally more positive work outcomes (Kammeyer et al., 2013; Brotheridge & Lee, 2003; Cottingham, Johnson, & Erickson, 2018).

In a meta-analysis of 109 independent studies, surface acting strategies were associated with a variety of harmful consequences to health, attitude, and performance, while deep acting strategies were not. Burnout, a phenomenon that occurs in response to prolonged exposure to emotional and interpersonal stressors and results in exhaustion, cynicism and inefficacy (Maslach, Schaufeli, & Leiter, 2001), is the most commonly studied consequence of surface acting (Mesmer-Magnus, DeChurch, & Waxman, 2012).

One protection against the harms of emotional labor is cultivating a “climate of authenticity” in the workplace, in which organizational members are more accepting of displays of different emotions (Ashkanazy & Doris, 2017). Authenticity can be defined as “the extent to which one is behaving according to what one considers to be their true or genuine self” (Ashforth & Tomiuk, 2012, p.184), and in the case of emotional authenticity, expressing emotions that accord with true feelings. Thus authenticity can be a quality of successful deep-acting, if a person achieves a state of genuinely feeling the emotion they are required to enact. This may help explain why deep acting strategies are not associated with the same harmful consequences as surface acting.

Identity factors: Gender, class and race

It has been convincingly argued that the very nature of EL is feminized (Stets & Turner, 2014). Hochschild primarily focused her original 1983 study on female flight attendants, stating that EL “affects the two sexes and the various social classes in distinctly different ways” (p. 20). She describes EL and emotion management as traditionally feminine tasks because, as an economically disadvantaged group, women tended to use emotional support, soothing, and care as valuable services to exchange for economic protection. Female flirtation and the creation of an atmosphere of sexual possibility for men is often a part of certain service roles, such as waitressing or hostessing; this was even more true when Hochschild conducted her research in the 1980s, prior to the #MeToo movement and the many legal protections against sexual harassment.

Women are significantly more likely to bear higher emotional labor burdens than men even when sharing the same job roles (Cottingham, Erickson, & Diefendorff, 2015;

Erickson, 2004; Gray, 2010; Meier, Mastracci, & Wilson, 2006; Morris & Feldman, 1996; Polleta & Tufail, 2016; Simpson & Stroh, 2004). When men perform EL, they also experience a status bonus that women who perform EL do not receive (Cottingham et al., 2015). Thus, women are found to experience more negative effects from emotional labor (Johnson & Spector, 2007; Han et al., 2018; Wang, Huang, Yin, & Ke, 2018; Walsh & Bartikowski, 2013).

As described above, the greater negative effects of emotional labor in women could be perceived as largely resulting from discrimination that, in many cultures including the US, places women lower in the social hierarchy, forcing them to deliver more servile and caring emotional performances. This is true for individuals belonging to marginalized ethnic, class, and racial identities as well, and these identities often intersect (Warner, 2008). As one would expect, people of color show a similar relationship with EL as women, in that they bear a higher burden of EL and suffer more negative consequences from its performance (Cottingham, Johnson, & Erickson, 2018; Grandey, Kern, & Frone, 2007; Evans & Moore, 2015; Harlow, 2003). These higher EL burdens should also be thought to include the “emotional tax” that women and people of color pay in the workplace, due to feeling on guard to protect themselves against gender and racial bias and stereotypes (Travis & Thorpe-Moscon, 2018).

Discrimination thus plays an important role in EL expectations, performance, and outcomes. A helpful lens to use when thinking about the multiple and overlapping identities that can affect an individual’s performance of emotional labor is the concept of intersectionality (Crenshaw, 1989), which acknowledges the multidimensionality of oppressed conditions in society. Rather than seeing each condition of discrimination as

singular, we should see these conditions as compounded by their coexistence, such that, for example, a woman of color has a fundamentally different experience than a White woman. Immigration status should also be considered one such condition that can add to and make distinctive the experience of emotional labor performance.

Cross-cultural research on EL

Culture is the way people use language and other symbolic tools to participate in a community, with particular attention to “the configurations of routine ways of doing things in any community’s approach to living” (Rogoff, 2003, p.3). Culture has not been an explicit focus of much emotional labor research. There is a small body of research comparing EL’s function in non-Western cultures to its function in North America and Western Europe (Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013). This cross-cultural research primarily looked at EL performance by native-born members of Asian cultures who work in their country of origin. Most of this research is conducted in China (see Wang et al., 2019; Yin, Wang, Huang, & Li, 2018), where economic liberalization has seen a boom in corporate and entrepreneurial culture over the past few decades (Rosen, Whang, & Wang, 2011).

This research has collectively suggested that EL is more effortful and harmful in cultures where there is a larger gap between the everyday emotion regulation strategies of a culture and the expectations for emotion management at work (Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013). In Hochschild’s (1983) terms of feeling rules, certain cultures focus more on an individual’s emotional entitlements, making EL feel wrong or uncomfortable since it forces the individual to ignore entitlements owed to him or her; other cultures focus more on an individual’s emotional obligations, making EL feel more natural and proper as it is

a form of paying these obligations. This would also suggest that emotional labor based on imported feeling rules would have higher personal cost when it is inconsistent with the self-definition a person has derived from his or her culture of origin (Syed, Ali, & Winstanley, 2005; Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013).

In North American cultural contexts, it has been posited that emotions are conceived as an expression of individuality (Markus & Kitayama, 1991), thus masking and controlling them is seen as a constraint on individuality (Mesquita & Delvaux, 2013). Cross-cultural researchers suggest that there are collectivistic cultures, such as those of East Asia, where people are more likely to view emotions as byproducts of relationships; a normal emotional regulatory goal in these cultures is maintaining harmony with the group (Mesquita et al., 2006). A collectivistic cultural context would thus make certain types of surface acting less discordant, since they mimic the suppressive emotional management strategies of everyday life in those cultures.

This theory has been borne out in empirical findings. Allen, Diefendorff, and Ma (2013) found a weaker relationship between emotional labor and burnout in Chinese service workers as compared to US service workers. This may correspond to the value that is said to be placed on emotional control in Confucian cultures like China, contrasted with the emphasis on autonomy and emotional authenticity in the US. Differences in EL have also been found between Western cultures. For example, expressing anger at work was considered more acceptable in France and Israel than in the US (Grandey, Rafaeli, Wirtz, & Steiner, 2010) and French workers have shown a weaker relationship between EL and job dissatisfaction (Grandey, Fisk, & Steiner, 2005).

While this research is interesting in highlighting the ways cultural meanings and values impact the expected relationships between EL and its potentially harmful consequences, it does not illuminate the process of EL when communicated across cultures, as in the case of immigrant workers. Many factors come into play when people of different cultures interact on an emotional level. For example, findings from emotion research suggest that individuals are worse at recognizing emotions of members from different cultural groups when compared to their own (Elfenbein & Ambady, 2002). Molinsky (2016) argues that interactions between cultures involve cross-cultural code-switching, i.e. “the act of purposefully modifying one's behavior, in a specific interaction in a foreign setting, to accommodate different cultural norms for appropriate behavior” (p. 623).

In one of the few studies examining intercultural EL, Menon & Narayan (2015) found that, when comparing US university faculty teaching in the US to those teaching in China, individuals in a foreign culture engaged in more surface acting compared to individuals working in their own culture, who employed more deep acting. This suggests that intercultural context does change the nature and experience of EL. In the next section I will detail why this may be, by describing research on immigrants and how their circumstances create a unique backdrop for emotional labor experiences.

Immigrants and emotional labor

The immigrant experience of EL has, thus far, been underexamined, despite the fact that US workplaces are becoming increasingly diversified by immigrants (Maidment, 2003) and the many indications that immigrants bring unique factors to bear on the EL process (Ramos-Villagrana, Garcia-Izquierdo, & Garcia-Izquierdo, 2011). The literature

on immigrant experience shows many avenues through which it might enrich research of EL. The act of crossing from one culture to another causes subtle and implicit cultural scripts, such as those involved in EL, to appear more prominent, as they are in the process of changing. Hochschild (2003) offers an argument to this effect by saying that “we are most likely to sense a feeling rule as a feeling rule, and deep acting as deep acting, not when we are strongly attached to a culture or role but when we are moving from one culture or one role to another” (p. 75).

The concepts of acculturation and emotional socialization suggest that immigrants are undergoing emotional processes as a part of their migratory experience that would complicate the performance of emotional labor. Individuals who migrate to a new culture as adults have experienced deep cultural learning of the norms, ideals, and customs for how emotions should be experienced and displayed to others, prior to entering a new context in which the norms, ideals, and customs may be radically different. In addition, the process of migrating creates unique pressures and experiences of its own, as adjusting to a new culture is associated with stresses on mental well-being, health, social status, and social ties. Immigrant status may be looked upon as a marginalized status, and imply experiences similar to those of women and racial minorities in the workplace. The immigrant experience is thus distinctive and worthy of attention in the domain of emotional labor.

Emotional socialization

From birth, all cultures teach infants and children how to regulate and manage their emotions in order to participate in social life. While this teaching is universal, the methods and goals for emotion management vary by culture. Evidence for differences in

emotional patterns and emotion management strategies between cultural groups, as well as explanation for how they occur, can be seen in research on emotional socialization.

Emotional socialization is the training process children go through in all cultures, aimed at promoting their emotional competence within the cultural context of their caregivers (Friedlmeier, Corapci & Cole, 2011). This context forms caregivers' expectations of what expressions and experiences of emotion are appropriate in a child; emotional competence, then, is defined as the child's ability to fulfill these cultural expectations. These expectations are connected to cultural values, of which two broad types have been defined: individualistic and collectivistic/relational (Greenfield, Keller, Fuligni, & Maynard, 2003; Matsumoto, 1991; Friedlmeier et al., 2011).

Most Western European and US contexts emphasize individualistic emotional competence, which involves the promotion of self-sufficiency, autonomy and independence through such manifestations as creativity, assertiveness, and high self-esteem (Greenfield et al., 2003). The expression of "ego-focused" emotions, such as anger, pride, and disgust, is more readily tolerated in these contexts, as they help to assert the inner state of autonomous, goal-directed individuals (Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Empirical findings support the idea that parents in these cultures encourage and accept the experience of children's negative emotions, scaffolding self-regulation while providing comfort and aid (Gottman, Katz, & Hooven, 1997).

In individualistic cultures, the dismissal, denial, criticism, or punishment of negative emotions is seen as impeding the development of emotional competence (Gottman et al., 1997), and this set of beliefs can be seen in both parenting practices (Gottman et al., 1997) and school curricula (Izard, Trentacosta, King, & Mostow, 2004).

In contrast, collectivistic/relational emotional competence is emphasized in many Asian, Latin American, and Eastern European contexts, and it involves a prioritization of courtesy and comportment in deference to hierarchical relationships, social harmony, and the interests of the group over those of the individual (Ramirez, 1991; Valdéz, 1996; Matsumoto, 1991). Values such as respect for elders and family loyalty are promoted, while ego-focused emotions are viewed as potentially disruptive to the group and requiring strict control (Wang, 2003). In these cultures, emotional competence is taught through knowledge of display rules and interpersonal sensitivity, and the other-focused emotions of shame and sympathy are encouraged (Mesquita & Albert, 2007). These cultures highlight the interdependence between individuals, rather than autonomy, and train emotional behavior in children that is consistent with successful interdependent functioning.

In all cultures, emotional socialization occurs through similar means. Though fewer studies have been conducted outside of the US, findings seem fairly consistent that emotional socialization is an embedded aspect of parenting, and often involves conversations between parent and child about past and present emotional events (Friedlmeier et al., 2010). Through these conversations, and through selective attention and response to certain emotional expressions over others, caregivers label and model emotions for children in a way that transmits cultural values. The gendered nature of emotional labor can be traced back to gendered emotional socialization in early childhood. In many cultures, including mainstream North America, girls are socialized to restrain assertive emotions such as anger, and more freely express vulnerable emotions

like sadness and fear, whereas boys are taught to more freely express anger, and conceal or suppress fear and sadness (Stets & Turner, 2014).

Acculturation

Immigration necessarily involves acculturation. In psychology, acculturation is understood to be the process of cultural change that occurs when individuals come into continuous first-hand contact with a new culture (Birman & Addae, 2015; Redfield, Linton, & Herskovits, 1936). Berry (2005) identified four common psychological strategies of acculturation in immigrants. These strategies vary in the extent that they retain the heritage culture and the extent to which they participate in the host culture. These strategies are biculturalism, separation, assimilation, and marginalization (Berry, 2005).

Assimilation is characterized by high involvement with the host culture and little maintenance of ties to the heritage culture. Biculturalism is an integration of high involvement in both the host and the heritage cultures; this strategy can be seen as additive, in that it adds a new cultural identity without the loss of one's original identity (Birman & Addae, 2015). Separation involves solely maintaining identification with the heritage culture, while avoiding interaction with the host culture. Marginalization, in turn, is a strategy in which little identification is made with either culture, sometimes due to circumstances of discrimination or exclusion (Berry, 2005).

For Berry, these strategies were seen as choices that immigrants make consciously; however, later researchers have argued that some aspects of immigrant adaptation are less conscious and less chosen. Acculturation behaviors, for example, may

be limited by the availability of opportunities to engage in heritage cultural activities after migrating (Birman & Trickett, 2001).

Immigration-related stressors

Acculturative stress is a term used to describe physical, psychological, and social distress caused by the acculturation process (Berry, 1970). This distress often takes the form of anxiety, depression, feelings of marginality and alienation, psychosomatic symptoms, and identity confusion (Berry, Kim, Minde, & Mok, 1987). Empirically, acculturative stress is positively correlated with anxiety, depression and suicidal ideation (Hovey & King, 1996; Lumley, Katsikitis, & Statham, 2018; Sirin, Sin, Clingain, & Rogers-Sirin, 2019). Even without discussing the importance of cultural factors influencing emotional experience, this unique stress alone can easily amplify the difficulty that immigrants face while performing emotionally laborious tasks at work, suggesting that the immigrant experience of EL is distinctive.

Another specific stressor that many immigrants face is unemployment and underemployment, as they often struggle to get recognition for the skills, training, and education that they bring from their country of origin (Lane & Lee, 2018; Dean & Wilson, 2009). Both unemployment and underemployment have been shown to lead to depression and low self-esteem (Frank, & Hou, 2017; Friedland, & Price, 2003)

Impact of language acquisition

Immigrants from non-English speaking countries also must cope with the challenge of language acquisition, which can make many aspects of work more challenging. EL may be particularly difficult in a second language context. Code switching, or alternation between languages in a single conversation, seems more likely

to occur following strong negative emotions (Williams, Srinivasan, Liu, Lee, & Zhou, 2019) which may make surface acting and emotional suppression more difficult for immigrant workers from different language backgrounds attempting to work in English. In Williams et al.'s experimental study, in which a puzzle challenge was used to induce emotions, the authors found that emotional arousal, especially negative arousal, led to more spontaneous code-switching. The proposed reason for this is that bilingualism requires more cognitive control than monolingualism, and emotional arousal reduces cognitive control.

Displaying composure in a second language may also make it harder to choose effective emotion regulation strategies. Gust, Petermann, and Koglin (2014) found that immigrant children tended to show less emotion knowledge and struggle more than native-born German children to generate and assess the effectiveness of emotion regulation strategies. Lower levels of emotion knowledge were partially mediated by language skills. Similar findings have been shown in samples of Latino immigrant children in the US (Perez Rivera & Dunsmore, 2011; Downs, Strand, & Cerna, 2007), and Chinese immigrant children (Doan & Wang, 2010; Wang, 2003).

Emotional acculturation

Emotional acculturation refers to a recent vein of research exploring what happens when an individual socialized into a culturally specific set of emotional norms crosses into a different cultural context. De Leersnyder (2017) was the first to conceptualize this process of emotion change, and has performed a series of empirical studies with Korean-Americans and Turkish-Belgians that has provided data supporting this theory.

This research has shown that immigrants who arrive with emotional patterns consistent with their culture of origin begin to resemble the emotional patterns of their host culture; the longer an immigrant resides in the host culture, the closer this resemblance becomes, with second generation immigrants showing almost no difference from native-born individuals (De Leersnyder, Mesquita, & Kim, 2011). While this field is still new, it has profound implications for how an immigrant worker might navigate EL demands. Findings suggest that more recent immigrants may have a harder time negotiating between heritage cultural norms and those proscribed by the display rules of a US work environment, since these rules are likely to show a greater disparity with their own emotional patterns.

Evidence from emotional acculturation research suggests that immigrants are undergoing this process throughout their lives, especially during the initial years of their migration. This would make the performance of emotional labor more complex, as it appears that the level of emotional acculturation would influence the congruence of both deep acting and surface acting, and the consequent outcomes experienced.

Russian culture

Russia has long been a multiethnic and multinational empire stretching over a huge swath of Asia and Europe, making the culture of Russian speakers incredibly diverse and heterogeneous (Riasanovsky & Steinberg, 2005). Russian speakers originate from modern-day Russia as well as the nations of Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, Estonia, Georgia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Latvia, Lithuania, Moldova, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Ukraine, and Uzbekistan, which were former republics of the Soviet Union (Ryazanova-Clarke, 2014). This diversity makes it difficult to define the culture of Russian-speakers

as a monolith. This vast region was historically united under the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR), from 1922 to 1991, and used Russian as the *lingua franca* (Hosking, 1990). Prior to the advent of the USSR, Russian imperial rule similarly united this region as a political entity (Riasanovsky & Steinberg, 2005). These historical circumstances allow for the identification of some commonalities in the culture of Russian speakers.

The Soviet Union was known for authoritarian rule and the suppression of many human rights considered basic in the US, including freedom of religious practice and freedom of speech (Gold, 1992). Governance and decision-making were very centralized and imposed from top-down, with high levels of punishment for negative results, errors, or defiance (Fey & Denison, 2003). In enforcing this top-down rule, the Soviet state was known for a complex bureaucracy that lacked transparency and was often corrupt and arbitrary in its treatment of individual citizens (Doern & Goss, 2013). Defiance of the state was punished by physical violence, imprisonment in labor camps, forced exile, and death (Drob, Tasso, & Griffo, 2016; Wheatcroft, 1999).

These historical circumstances have shaped the psychology, interpersonal behavior, and values of the region. Russia has been posited as a collectivistic culture, similar to Asian cultures (Hofstede, 2001). The ancestral collectivism of Slavic tribal society and the Russian Orthodox Church may have influenced the drive to adopt communism in the revolution of 1917 (Khan & Panarina, 2017). Yet the collectivism and interdependence of Russian culture today appears to take a more local form, in response to the pressures and deprivations of Soviet state collectivism. Collectivism appears to focus on a strong alliance to the extended family and close friends, rather than allegiance

to larger and more impersonal groups (Khan & Panarina, 2017; Bradley 1999; Markowitz, 1994).

Relatedly, because the Soviet state was perceived as corrupt, bureaucratic, and impersonal, there appears to be an enhanced need in Russian culture for authenticity, reciprocity, and trusting friendships even in contexts that other cultures might treat with more formality (McCarthy & Puffer, 2003). Researchers have observed a tendency of Russian entrepreneurs to rely heavily on personal relationships and informal exchange in business dealings (Doern & Goss, 2013; Morris, 2011). This emphasis on genuine personal connection appears to coincide with a high barrier between the public and the private, and a wariness towards strangers. McCarthy and Puffer (2003) assert that Russian business managers have a reticence to share knowledge and a tendency to work with those with whom they are familiar and to exclude perceived outsiders.

The Soviet state's repressive practices were quite complex, and employed a secret police force, the KGB, to surveille its citizens (Wheatcroft, 1999). Remnants of the KGB organization continue to play a significant role in Russian political and social life today, emblemized by the fact that the current leader of Russia, Vladimir Putin, himself rose from their ranks (Marten, 2017). This context would understandably make the public sphere feel more treacherous for Russians than for Americans. Christophel (1999) argues that the boundary between public and private expression in Russia is strongly defined, and supports this assertion with a survey of Russian college students that found them less willing to initiate communication with strangers than comparable samples in the US, Sweden, Finland, Australia and Puerto Rico.

The Russian attitude towards smiling in public is another cultural trait that appears linked to this firm boundary between public and private life. A famous Russian aphorism states “smiling with no reason is a sign of stupidity” (Krys et al., 2016). Given the sensitive nature of public communication in the Soviet context, this aphorism makes a lot of sense. Unlike in the United States, where it is common practice to smile at strangers in a variety of contexts, in Russia a smile is a more personal and sincere form of communication reserved for intimates (Arapova, 2016). Humphrey’s (2018) ethnography of northeastern Russia observes “their default position is another ‘natural’ straight face, for what Russians say is that smiles should arise spontaneously ‘from the heart’ with people you know and like” (p. 45).

This constitutes markedly different public display rules for positive emotions in Russia as compared to in the United States. Despite a strong emphasis on the importance and intensity of emotional experience in Russian culture (Wierzbicka, 1998), Russia’s displays of emotion in public can appear quite reserved in comparison to those of other cultures. Random unprompted smiles, especially those from unfamiliar individuals, are perceived quite differently in Russia than in the United States. In a 2016 study of over 5,000 respondents from 44 cultures, Russians rated smiling individuals comparatively lower on intelligence and honesty than all other cultures aside from Japan, South Korea, southern India and Iran (Krys et al., 2016). This finding was moderated by gender, as all cultures studied appeared to respond more positively to smiling women than to smiling men.

A certain type of pragmatic and pessimistic worldview has also been observed among Russian survey respondents (Fey & Denison, 2003; Holt et al., 1994). For

example, in a survey study comparing Russian and U.S. undergraduates studying business, Russian respondents scored significantly higher on measures of social cynicism (Alexandra, Torres, Kovbasyuk, Addo, & Ferreira, 2017). Social cynicism describes a negative outlook on people and institutions, characterized by distrust, a belief in the corrosive effects of power and status, a belief in the inevitability of opportunism and social exploitation, and a perception that shows of goodwill are ineffective and frustrating (Hui and Hui, 2009). In keeping with these findings on Russian worldview, Russian respondents have been observed to spend significantly more time attending to negative over positive visual stimuli, as compared to Americans (Grossman, Ellsworth, & Hong, 2011).

Perhaps influenced by the strongly top-down approach of Soviet governance, research has consistently found a higher power distance in Russian respondents when compared to US respondents (Bollinger, 1994; Bradley, 1999; Naumov & Puffer, 2000; Hofstede, 2001). Power distance, a concept pioneered by Hofstede (1980), is the expectation that power will be distributed unequally in institutions, organizations, and society at large (McCarthy & Puffer, 2003). It can be manifested in the degree to which individuals attempt to either acknowledge and respect, or ignore, power and status discrepancies. The US consistently displays a remarkably low level of power distance, in contrast to Russia (Khan & Panarina, 2017).

Research has also consistently found that Russia evinces a greater avoidance of uncertainty as compared to the US (Bradley, 1999; Michailova & Hutschings, 2006; Naumov & Puffer, 2000). Uncertainty avoidance, another concept pioneered by Hofstede (1980), entails the degree to which individuals feel uncomfortable in surprising,

ambiguous, unexpected or unknowable situations. Avoidance of uncertainty can be seen in a desire for planning, structure, and support in decision-making.

Russian-speaking immigrants

As of 2017, over 400,000 individuals born in Russia are residing in the United States (US Census Bureau). Russian-speaking immigrants began to migrate to the United States en masse in the 1870s, with this first wave of migration being primarily Jewish (Simon, 1997). A second wave of migration from Russia occurred after the Russian revolution in 1917 (Lipman, S., 2012). In the late 1960s, the Soviet Union began to allow the exit of religious refugees, and a total of approximately 100,000 Jewish refugees arrived in the United States (Markowitz, 1993). Immigrants from this period and beyond are more likely to still speak Russian than immigrants of previous generations, who assimilated into the US mainstream (Dubinina & Polinsky, 2007). Immigration from Russia increased again in the early 1990s, as the fall of the Soviet Union created new instabilities that provoked the migration of more Russian Jews as well as other groups.

As can be inferred from the abovementioned migration history, the majority of immigrants in the US from the FSU are ethnically Jewish (Rosenthal, 1975). Estimates are as high as 70% (Berger, 2011). The exact number and percentage of Russian Jews in the US is difficult to obtain, however, because the US Census has not asked about religious affiliation since the 1950s, and the definition of Jewishness is contested. Jewishness is both a religious identity and an ethnic identity. A growing percentage of Jewish Americans identify as Jewish while also identifying as nonreligious (Pew Research Council, 2013). This question becomes particularly thorny when discussing

Russian Jews, whose identity was perceived radically differently in their country of origin than it is in the US (Birman, 1991).

Unlike modern American Jews, in Russia being Jewish has been historically understood as antithetical to being “Russian” (Birman, 1991). Jews in pre-revolutionary Russia often experienced violence in the form of pogroms, while Jews within the Soviet Union were the target of state Anti-Semitism, which barred them from jobs and positions in universities, as well as Stalinist purges of intellectuals (Gold, 1992). Jews were never allowed to assimilate fully, despite speaking Russian and achieving high levels of education and employment; their minority identity was inescapable, as their passports were stamped “Jew” (Gold, 1992). This was true regardless of a Russian Jewish individual’s religiosity or propensity to practice the Jewish faith. Because all religious observance was banned under Stalin, a significant portion of the Soviet Jews who left the country as religious refugees did not, in fact, practice any religion, and many of the younger generation were not familiar with Jewish culture (Gold, 1992).

The discrimination that Jews experienced in the Soviet Union is what led to their mass emigration and eventual settlement in the US. The majority of Russian-speaking immigrants in the United States have settled in various enclaves in New York City, including Hamilton Heights and Brighton Beach (Lipman, S., 2012). Ethnic enclaves are neighborhoods, often of lower income, where large numbers of individuals from the same ethnic background settle (Miller et al., 2009; Chiswick & Miller, 2005). Settling in enclaves is often a strategic first choice for new immigrants seeking convenient forms of support, hence why these locations are called “gateway communities” (Miller et al., 2009).

Ethnic enclaves provide access to familiar cultural items, allow immigrants to participate in social networks with language peers, and soften the transition between pre- and post-immigration life. Enclaves also increase access to necessary services for immigrants, such as interpreters, by concentrating the demand for them in certain locations (Miller et al., 2009). Enclaves can, however, reduce the need for, and thus the development of English language proficiency, which has in turn been associated with lower earnings among immigrants (Chiswick & Miller, 2005). Living in ethnic enclaves can also lead to underemployment, due to a lack of access to American social supports; this has been found true for Soviet Jewish immigrants (Vinokurov, Trickett, & Birman, 2017). It is important to note that Russian-speaking enclaves in the U.S. are known to be lacking in density of Russian speakers, often with less than 15% of the population recorded as speaking Russian (Birman & Trickett, 2001).

As a byproduct of their outsider status and their persecution, Jews in the FSU appear to have developed certain cultural traits that embody, in extreme form, the Russian values described in the previous section. Ethnographers of this group have observed a tendency to value trust and emotional authenticity, a tight inner circle, a strong alliance to the extended family, and a reserved display of public emotion that balks at public displays of enthusiastic friendliness (Markowitz, 1993; Markowitz, 1994; Gold, 1992). Ethnographer Steven Gold (1992) has observed that Soviet Jewish immigrants to the US found Soviet state collectivism coercive, and had no experience with voluntary organization, leading them to feel reluctant to create formal organizations. Thus, the cultural differences observed between Russians and Americans may be even more pronounced in Russian Jews.

Emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants

In summary, Russian-speaking immigrants are linked by certain cultural commonalities that emerged in countries of the FSU, possibly in response a history of repressive authoritarian rule. These commonalities include a reluctance to create formal organizations, a high need for interpersonal trust, and reserved public emotional display rules. These trends suggest a distinctive experience for Russian-speaking immigrants performing emotional labor in U.S. workplaces that often expect enthusiastic public emotional displays.

The current study

In qualitative inquiry, sensitizing concepts can suggest directions for research by giving a general sense of relevance and salience within a given topic (Blumer, 1954). By holding these concepts loosely in mind, a researcher creates a lens through which to approach the project, yet also allows the data to speak for itself and lead inductively to themes and conclusions. The sensitizing concepts for this project, which guided the construction of my interview guide (see Interview Guide in Appendix B), initial sampling, and initial data collection, were Hochschild's (1983) concept of emotional labor and its components of deep acting and surface acting, the concept of specific cultural norms for emotion expression and management that have been socialized in childhood, and De Leersnyder's (2017) concept of emotional acculturation. This matrix of concepts created a picture of immigrants as unique intercultural agents in the realm of emotional labor, operating within a second culture while continuing to carry emotional norms and proclivities from their culture of origin.

In the overwhelmingly service-oriented context of the US, millions of immigrant employees perform emotional labor every day, yet little is known about this experience. Despite the lack of culturally-focused research on emotional labor, evidence strongly suggests that emotional labor is culturally situated. Intercultural and multicultural contexts complicate the established understanding of how emotional labor works and what its outcomes are for workers. Russian culture, in particular, shows sharp contrasts with the culture of the US, suggesting that Russian-speaking immigrants would have a distinctive experience of emotional labor performance in US workplaces. By exploring Russian-speaking immigrants' experience of emotional labor, my project allowed for the examination of an intercultural context in the performance and experience of emotional labor. This both illuminated how US workplaces can be made more comfortable for Russian-speaking immigrants, and more broadly helped to explain how culture influences the emotional labor process

Chapter 3: Methods

Research paradigm

In this study I employed a phenomenological research paradigm, which takes the epistemological position that data is contained within the perspectives of people experiencing the phenomenon being studied (Groenewald, 2004). Phenomenology concerns itself with people's lived experience (Green, 1997). "The aim of the investigator is the reconstruction of the inner world of experience of the subject" (Ellenberger, as cited in Hycner, 1999, pp. 153). In order to gain knowledge within this paradigm, a researcher must interact with and gather descriptions from participants, who are the expert informants on the topic. Participants are those who can describe the phenomenon firsthand.

Phenomenology was ideal for investigating this topic, because the impact of acculturation on emotional labor experiences had not been extensively studied previously, making quantitative data collection and analysis untenable. Quantitative analysis would require the use of pre-existing measures asking general questions about emotional labor, without adequately addressing the unique, specific experiences of immigrant workers (Menon & Narayanan, 2015).

Qualitative research better addresses lesser understood experiences embedded in cultural practices and systems that require explication, because it offers the opportunity for thick description of these experiences. Phenomenology is particularly suited to portraying the subjective experience of emotion and its surrounding context, because it foregrounds the knowledge and self-understanding created by participants, who are the experts on their own experiences. "The operative word in phenomenological research is

‘describe’” (Groenewald, 2004, p. 44). This method approaches phenomena in an open-ended manner, with the goal of creating a description that matches participants’ subjective experience as accurately as possible.

Within the phenomenological paradigm, researchers are understood to approach their topics with their own individual subjectivity and explicit beliefs, which is why self-reflection and consciousness of positionality is key to producing credible work (Groenewald, 2004; Mouton and Marais, 1990). In the statement at the end of this chapter, I will discuss my own positionality and the reasons I was drawn to this topic.

Participants and recruitment

The intention of this project was to gather descriptions of the Russian-speaking immigrant worker’s experiences of emotional labor, so participants were required to be Russian-speaking immigrants working in positions that involved emotional labor. Immigrants, for the purposes of this study, were defined as individuals who had moved as adults from their country of origin to the United States, with the intention of living in the US; thus, they were not tourists or transients. Explicit questions about legal immigration status were not asked, as this information is sensitive and might have made some participants uncomfortable.

Emotional labor was defined via Hochschild (2003): “the management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display” in a work role (p. 7). The sample contained participants who fit the above description of immigrant and had experiences related to the above description of emotional labor at their current jobs. I exclusively sampled Russian-speaking immigrants, defined as immigrants born in the USSR or one of the nations of the FSU, who spoke Russian as their native language.

All participants were over the age of 18. Participants also spoke enough English proficiency to understand the consent process and be interviewed in English. In order to be eligible to participate, individuals were required to have immigrated as an adult (age 18 or older); these individuals had been enculturated into Russian culture throughout their childhood and thus were still undergoing the acculturation process. I also preferentially sampled individuals who had been employed in their country of origin, in order to have a basis for comparison between their current work experience and that of their home country, though one of my participants had not been employed previous to migration and had been a full-time student. Participants did not need to be employed in the same kind of job in their home country as the job they currently perform.

Participants were initially chosen via sampling from the researcher's existing social networks and personal referrals. A reliance on social networks as a source of participants for this project was consistent with research on Russia's cultural tendency to rely on trusted personal networks to accomplish tasks (McCarthy & Puffer, 2003; Gold, 1992). Sampling proceeded through a snowball method, using purposive sampling to select participants from among referrals. Snowball sampling, also known as referral sampling, is a common practice in qualitative research, in which a few members of the target population who are easily accessible are identified by the researcher, and then these participants are asked to locate and identify further potential participants (Duignan, 2016).

On May 27th, 2020, I posted an IRB-approved recruitment flyer (see Appendix B) on Facebook in order to seek a wider range of participants. 7 participants were recruited via this flyer. The participants were selected using purposive sampling, in an attempt to

find maximum variation with respect to workplaces, experiences, and countries of origin, within the bounds previously described.

Both Boyd (2001) and Creswell (2013) recommend a sample size of 10 for a phenomenological study, though some authors suggest that sample sizes as low as three would be appropriate, given the focus on individual-level experience (Smith & Osbourne, 2003). I interviewed a total of 11 participants. One participant was excluded from further analyses, because he did not meet inclusion criteria despite passing through initial screening process. Though he had arrived in the US at age 21, he had left Russia at the age of 14, thus he was not an adult at the time of his migration to the U.S. Within the remaining group of 10, I sampled 3 men and 7 women. Their ages ranged from 24-66, with an average age of 43.7. They represented a range of migration timelines, from just under one year in the US to 30 years in the US, with an average time spent in the US of 18.7 years. All participants racially identified as White, and 6 out of 10 identified ethnically as Jewish. A full list of the demographics of the sample can be found in Table 1.

Participants' jobs ranged from dance instructor, to grant developer, to hotel concierge, to family physician. These jobs can be roughly grouped into three categories: educated professionals – who work white collar jobs that required a college degree; health professionals – who work in the healthcare (e.g. doctor, nurse); and sales and Service professionals – who sell goods or services. Six participants lived in ethnic enclaves, while four did not. Living in an ethnic enclave did not appear to have an impact on the type of emotional labor experiences described.

TABLE 1: Participant Characteristics

<i>Name*</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Race</i>	<i>Ethnicity</i>	<i>Country of origin</i>
Annika	F	61	W	Jewish	Ukraine
Maria	F	66	W	Jewish	Ukraine
Svetlana	F	25	W	Muslim	Russia
Katarina	F	29	W	Ukrainian	Ukraine
Vlad	M	55	W	Jewish	Russia
Lana	F	48	W	Jewish	Moldova
Dasha	F	24	W	Russian	Russia
Peter	M	49	W	Jewish	Russia
Natalia	F	35	W	Caucasian	Ukraine
Gabriel	M	45	W	Jewish	Uzbekistan

*pseudonyms were used

Sampling these 10 participants across a range of ages, genders, geographic origins, migration timelines, and professions allowed me to explore common themes across individuals' experiences while highlighting the differences within the group, as well as focusing on the rich, deep, data of individuals' lived experiences of the phenomenon.

Data collection and storage

I conducted in-depth, semi-structured interviews in a conversational style, in English, with immigrant employees who use emotional labor at work. The structure of the interviews allowed us to focus on emotionally salient factors. Interviews lasted between 60-90 minutes. These interviews were the primary unit of analysis in this study,

consistent with the phenomenological perspective on data (Groenewald, 2004). Interview questions delved into the heart of participants' feelings, beliefs, experiences, and meanings (Welman & Kruger, 1999). Participants were also asked to fill out a brief demographic form (Appendix C). Participants were given a \$20 Amazon gift card, as a token of gratitude for their participation, prior to starting the interview.

Participants were identified by pseudonym and date of interview throughout the research process. Each interview was audio-recorded and transcribed shortly after recording. Data files for each recording and transcription were labelled with the corresponding pseudonym and date of interview. These files were kept on password-protected cloud computing software through the University of Miami. All handwritten notes taken during interviews (memos), which likewise excluded real names and used pseudonyms and interview dates, were kept in secure files in the researcher's office. Observational memos (or field notes) taken while interviewing were kept separately from theoretical, methodological and analytical notes, in order to increase researcher self-reflexivity and avoid imposing a false structure upon the raw data (Groenewald, 2004). Morgan (1997, pp. 57-58) describes field notes as "part of the analysis rather than the data collection" because they involve interpretation.

Data explication

In phenomenological research, data analysis is often referred to as data explication, to avoid the association between analysis and the taking apart of an object (Groenewald, 2004). Rather, in the process of data explication, the holistic subjectivity of participants is preserved and continually referred back to, in order to attempt to reconstruct a lived experience in its entirety.

I began explicating the data immediately and simultaneously with data collection. Data explication informed my sampling decisions, as I pursued concepts and themes that arose through the explication process. I used “memos” (Miles & Huberman, 1984), also called field notes, to record and date my thoughts, observations, and reflections while collecting and analyzing data. This allowed me to maintain a balance between descriptive and reflective notetaking, so that my subjective impressions and intuitions were not absorbed into the participants’ reports (Groenewald, 2004). It also allowed me to create an “audit trail” as I proceeded, with dated memos of my thoughts and decisions during the research process (Shenton & Smith, 2004).

In explicating the data, I followed Hycner’s (1999) five step process, which consists of: 1. Bracketing and phenomenological reduction; 2. Delineating units of meaning; 3. Clustering of units of meaning to form themes; 4. Summarizing and validating each interview and modifying the summary when necessary; 5. Extracting general and unique themes from all data and writing a composite summary. I used the ATLAS.ti software package, alongside manual writing, to aid this process (Kelle, 1995).

Bracketing

Bracketing is the self-conscious stance of a researcher towards a phenomenon of inquiry, in which one attempts to take an open-minded approach, absent presuppositions and biases, and allow the phenomenon to develop its own meaning from participant accounts (Fouche, 1993). This approach is called phenomenological reduction, in the sense that it reduces the phenomenon to the “pure subjectivity” of participants (Lauer, 1958, p.50). I bracketed, as much as possible, through self-awareness and self-reflection throughout the research process. My positionality statement, one example of bracketing,

will further explain how I have attempted to approach this project with self-reflective awareness of my own assumptions and biases. Further bracketing will occur through memo writing during the research process and weekly debriefing with an expert consultant during the data collection and analysis process.

Bracketing occurred throughout the sampling, data collection, and data analysis phases. In the data collection phase, while interviewing participants, I created memos during and after each interview to document my impressions and emotional responses. These memos served as a form of bracketing. During the data analysis phase, when my own experiences or assumptions arose as a point of reference while I was rereading the participants' accounts, I wrote memos about this as well. In the sampling phase, bracketing occurred as I self-reflecting about my choice of participants and attempted to ensure that it was not a result of personal biases, but rather a reflection of the research questions. In the data explication phase and as I decided to do follow-up interviews, I wrote memos and discussed the decision with my expert consultant, Dr. Dina Birman. We also engaged in dialogue surrounding the coding process and every step of the analysis and writing of results. Dr. Debbie Liu Lee also audited the data after the initial coding was complete.

Coding

As the very first step of the coding process, I read through the entirety of each interview transcript several times, in order to grasp the meanings each participant conveyed about their experiences. Because I transcribed every interview myself, I became intimate with the details of each participant's narrative. In the initial coding phase, I coded each interview transcript line-by-line to identify units of relevant meaning,

with a focus on the phenomenon under investigation (Hycner, 1999; Peoples, 2020). A meaning unit identifies a trait or quality of the phenomenon being explored. An example of a unit of meaning identified early on in the coding process can be seen in this quote from Annika's interview: "And my concern was, as well as my husband's concern, our children. We didn't want them, in any shape or form, not to be assimilated to the level that I would appreciate." This meaning unit illustrated her desire for her family, particularly her children, to assimilate to the United States.

As I performed line coding, I compared units of meaning and eliminated redundancies (Moustakas, 1994). I considered the literal content, the frequency and significance with which a unit of meaning was mentioned, and how it was mentioned during the interview (Groenewald, 2004). Units of meaning were then closely examined to find meaningful common groupings of units (Creswell, 2013; Moustakas, 1994). These groupings, or clusters, were derived by revisiting the raw data, and making iterative comparisons between the interviews and the list of non-redundant units (Groenewald, 2004; Hycner, 1999). Each cluster was then assessed and reviewed to find the unifying theme, or essential feature, of the groupings.

After meaning clusters were grouped thematically, I produced individual descriptions of the phenomenon, in which I restated each participants' story and organized the specifics of each participant's experience thematically around the research questions. This allowed me to return to the data with an eye towards answering the research questions.

Follow-up interviews

At this point, I assessed the accuracy of my themes and descriptions, and addressed gaps in my information, through member checks and follow-up interviews. I transcribed each follow-up interview, read through it several times, and integrated the information into my analysis. An example of the type of clarification I obtained from follow-up interviews can be seen in the following quote, from an interview with Dasha, where I sought to better understand how gender affected the type of emotional displays required of her at work:

“Interviewer: Do you notice any difference between the waiters, the way the waiters act, versus the waitresses, or the way you act?

Dasha: What I notice, personally, is that the guys, they’re more kinda like short and sweet. That kind of situation. While the ladies ask a lot of questions, like assuring everything's okay, there's anything else they can do. You know, that kind of style. Like the guys just don’t.

Interviewer: Short and sweet, what does that mean?

Dasha: So, like, they would just come to your table and be like, “are you guys doing okay? All right, I'm going,” Like, this type of stuff. And, while the girls at the restaurant, they usually like, “Oh, are you doing okay? Do you need anything? Is everything fine?” You know, like, asking all these questions, throwing it at them.

Interviewer: What do you think would happen if you acted more “short and sweet”?

Dasha: I feel like, I don't think people would take it as well as, as they would take it from a guy. Because I have done it before, but at my hotel job. I kind of like tried to make it

short and sweet. But people take it as if I would have a bad day and didn't want to talk to them at all.

Interviewer: So you feel like they'd react negatively.

Dasha: Rather, yes.”

My follow-up interviews particularly focused on gender differences in experiences of emotional labor. Information gathered from follow-up interviews like this one allowed for a revision and expansion of the individual descriptions, and a synthesis of a composite description of the phenomenon, including the essences and meanings of the phenomenon. This final description of the phenomenon can be found in Chapter 4. A table summarizing the final themes that emerged in response to the research questions can also be found in Chapter 4, including each subtheme and quotes to illustrate the subthemes.

Ongoing sampling choices

Throughout the data collection and explication process, I kept my eyes open to the possibility of negative case analysis. Negative case analysis is the process of revising thematic findings through examining new cases that significantly diverge from the main emerging description (Allen, 2017). For example, one prominent negative case present in the findings was that of Gabriel, who did not experience himself to be performing emotional labor at all in his work role. The types of experiences he did share with other participants allowed me to flesh out the horizon of the experience of cultural adaptation among participants.

Other examples of the type of variation I explored involved seeking out a variety of careers, migration timelines, and social supports. After interviewing my first two

participants, who were highly educated and worked in highly verbal professions (social work and teaching), I sought out for individuals who were less educated and worked in jobs that were less verbal. I also continuously sought male participants to explore gender as a factor in these experiences.

I was able to find participants who had very different experiences of life in the U.S. For example, I had many participants share difficulties in learning English, but one participant, Dasha, acquired fluency quickly on-the-job while working at Starbucks, partly because she was immersed in her husband's all English-speaking social network and lived in an area without an immigrant community. Most participants described financial hardship upon first arriving, but Natalia arrived in an extremely economically secure position.

Negative cases and participants with different experiences from the majority were especially important in forming a thick description of emotional labor (Groenwald, 2004). By analyzing a breadth of emotional experience, I saw common factors emerge across participants.

Member checks

I performed member checks by bringing a description of the themes back to participants and asking for feedback on the accuracy of the descriptions captured (Groenewald, 2004). These checks occurred via email. I emailed all ten participants for these checks and received a total of four responses. Three participants opted to discuss the themes with me in greater depth over Zoom in follow-up interviews. All responses confirmed that the findings were accurate to their experiences.

Credibility

In accordance with the guidelines offered by Shenton & Smith (2004), this research was conducted in ways to maximize the credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability of my findings. Credibility addresses the question of how congruent findings are with reality (Shenton & Smith, 2004), and is increased through the adoption of well-established research methods like phenomenology.

I worked to develop rapport and trust with participants. This rapport-building was aided by the personal network connections that I used to locate some of the participants, which tacitly implied a social vetting process prior to our meeting. I also familiarized myself with the participants' context through reliance on key informants and written resources. During the interviews, I self-disclosed about my own background and interest in the topic, and responded to participants' desire to know more about me by answering their questions. Throughout, I tried to display respect for the customs of my participants, and create an environment of mutual trust and openness.

Rigorous self-reflection and disclosure of my bias and positioning also increased the credibility of this project. Beginning with my positionality statement at the end of this chapter, and continuing through data collection, coding, and analysis, I reflected on my role as a researcher and the ways that my personal experiences influenced research choices. I also maintained an audit trail of all decisions made during the research process.

The expert consultation I received throughout the coding process, and the scrutiny of codes by both peers and experts, aided to increase credibility of the findings. My dissertation co-chairs, Dr. Birman and Dr. Lee, both audited my coding. Dr. Birman is a cultural insider to the Russian-speaking immigrant community and a recognized expert

on immigrant acculturation, so she was also able to offer cultural insight during data explication. We met regularly to discuss bracketing, coding, and sampling choices. I also performed member checks and documented the responses I received, incorporating them into further coding stages.

Transferability

Transferability is the degree to which qualitative findings may be applicable to other situations, as an example within a broader group (Shenton & Smith, 2004). Through a highly detailed, thick description of context and research methods, including the number of participants, type of careers sampled, pre-migration careers, time spent in the United States, gender and ethnicity, and all data collection methods employed, I did my best to ensure that other qualitative researchers can judge how transferable my results may be to different contexts. For details on the characteristics and context of participants, see Tables 1 and 2.

Dependability

While qualitative research, with its attention to ever-changing aspects of culture, identity, and experience, does not expect that a given set of investigator observations will be exactly replicable at another point in time, dependability of findings can be ensured in similar ways to credibility, through an openly self-reflective and thick description of all aspects of the research process. This allows other researchers to appraise whether I produced plausible findings from the circumstances given, even if they may never be identically repeated.

Confirmability

Confirmability is the qualitative equivalent of objectivity; in the case of a phenomenology like the present study, the goal is not to be objective, but rather to preserve the subjectivity of the study's participants, without imposing my own characteristics and preferences. To increase confirmability, I noted possible areas of bias in my positionality statement, and used memos to make my personal biases explicit and increase my self-awareness (Peoples, 2020). I also kept an audit trail and transparently reported my research process and each decisions I made throughout the process to my expert consultant.

Because aspects of quality for this form of research overlap, they can be addressed together through the same best practices. At every point during this project, I provided as much background and contextual data as possible. While writing, I reflected on my positioning as the researcher and author, transparently disclosing my assumptions and biases as they affected research decisions. I recorded an audit trail during the research process through memos, a journal, and disclosure to peers and supervisors in order to self-reflect among a critical audience of fellow researchers (Shenton & Smith, 2004).

Ethical issues

The primary ethical issues involved in this study were concerns about confidentiality, fears about the repercussions of publicizing certain sensitive information, and discomfort participants may have experienced from answering research questions. To alleviate confidentiality concerns, the data was stored on a secure, password-protected, server and participants' real names were not used. Identifying details beyond names were

redacted from transcripts or changed. The interview experience was kept as private as possible, and identifying participant information was not seen by anyone other than the researcher. Participants were not asked any questions about their immigration status, and no information about immigration status was collected.

To address concerns about participant discomfort, an informed consent process was followed throughout data collection, and participants were told that they could withdraw their consent at any time and refuse to answer any questions that made them uncomfortable (see Consent Form in Appendix A). This study did not seek participants from vulnerable populations, such as minors, pregnant women, or people who are incarcerated. All study participants were adults.

Positionality Statement

Qualitative research relies on the subjective, rather than the elusive goal of objective truth (Shenton, 2004). A starting point for collecting data based on the subjectivity of participants is by acknowledging the subjectivity of the researcher. In the tradition of transparency and reflexivity, I have chosen to include a positionality statement describing the characteristics, identities, and biases I brought to this project (Wells & Stage, 2015).

I am a White woman, a secular Jew, a therapist, and a U.S. citizen who has never emigrated from my country of birth. In accordance with Patricia Arredondo's model of the Dimensions of Personal Identity (Arredondo, 1999), it is important to be attentive to the multiple fixed and flexible dimensions that contribute to my sense of self and my worldview as I approach this project within its sociopolitical and historical context. My US citizenship and the fact that I am not an immigrant myself are significant dimensions

of my personal identity that affect how I view the world. My female gender, and my work experience as a counseling psychology graduate student and a psychotherapist are also significant dimensions, as I will expand upon below.

Our historical moment plays a significant role in my current worldview, as the former president of the U.S. uses explicitly xenophobic and anti-immigrant rhetoric, whose platform rejected international humanitarian standards by banning refugees and certain immigrant groups from entry into the United States. The historical moment of the Trump presidency reinforced my dedication to approaching research in immigrant communities with respect and compassion, in contrast to the Trump discourse.

Using a lens that attended to the personal dimensions of my identity helped me to examine and contextualize my worldviews as I collect and explicate the data.

Arredondo's model points up dimensions of my identity on which I differed from my participants, and helped me consider how these differences affected our interactions, how we viewed each other, and how my own opinions and conclusions tended during the research process. I used Arredondo's model as a sensitizing lens throughout my data collection, as I wrangled with emergent aspects of my personal identity that affected my understanding of the data.

By making use of Arredondo's lens, I tried my best to remain as self-aware as possible. Prior to beginning data collection, I was aware that I possess privilege in my Whiteness, my status as a native English speaker, my US citizenship, and my professional/educational background as a PhD student. These dimensions of my personal identity afford me advantages in society that my participants may not experience.

In addition to Arredondo's model, I also incorporated the concept of representational ethics (Haarlamert, Birman, Oberoi, & Moore, 2017), so that I consciously reflected on the way that I portrayed my participants and the complexity of my own identity as a partial insider. My own family descends from Jewish immigrants who came to the United States from Russia and Ukraine three generations ago. For this reason, I share an ethnic and racial background with many of my participants, though I have no direct experience of modern-day Russian culture after seven decades of Soviet rule.

It is important to note that the Russian-speaking world includes people of multiple races, including a significant population of Central Asians from the former Soviet republics of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. Due to political and historical forces, the demographic composition of Russian-speaking immigrants to the United States is more homogeneous than that of modern-day Russia itself. The waves of Russian-speaking migration to the United States in the past century have primarily contained religious refugees, most of whom were Jewish.

This Jewish refugee population is seen as White in the United States, though they are considered differently in the FSU. Ethnic diversity in Russia is characterized by the concept of "nationality" or ethnicity, rather than race. In the FSU, where Jews are considered to be an ethnic group, Jewish identity is more racialized and minoritized than it is in the US. This affects the self-understanding of Russian-speaking Jews in ways that I did not intuitively recognize. Unlike many Russian-speaking Jews, I was raised with a US cultural understanding of my Jewishness as almost invisible; I did not, to my knowledge, experience institutional Anti-Semitism. I have always been able to be both

Jewish and American, whereas for Russian Jews, to be Jewish was by definition not to be an ethnic Russian. Several participants commented on their identities in these terms, saying that they do not consider themselves Russian because they are Jewish.

Due to my different background, and influenced by this group's experience of persecution, I may have been perceived as even more of an outsider to the community and viewed with some suspicion. Because of the importance of trust and personal relationships, it was even more important to work towards trusting rapport, ensure informed consent throughout data collection, and provide a clear explanation of my project's goals, sometimes several times, so that participants felt comfortable sharing with me.

To accomplish this, I introduced myself with transparency when talking about my study and explained the connection between my personal ethnic background and my interest in participants' experiences. I did not claim an insider status that I did not truly feel, resulting in multiple conversations in which I described my lack of background in the Russian language, and my family's cultural disconnect from the Yiddish and Slavic roots of my ancestors. I described my interest in Russian-speaking immigrant experiences and often asked if participants were comfortable responding to questions, including during the initial screening process. I remained open throughout each interview to answer further questions about myself and the project, whenever participants wished. Some participants took advantage of this invitation to ask me a great deal about myself, and this allowed us to recognize personal connections we shared beyond our ethnicity.

A factor that came up repeatedly during these encounters was the fact that I am not an immigrant myself. With no firsthand experience of immigration, I have been

careful not to impose my own assumptions about immigrant life upon this project. There is a danger, as in any research on potentially marginalized populations, that I could reify a pathologizing or deficit-based understanding of the group. The deficit model implicitly reinforces the image of majority, White, native-born populations as superior. By framing this project as an exploration of the distinctiveness of the immigrant experience, rather than a search for how and why the immigrant experience is “worse” than that of US nationals, I tried to avoid deficit model-type thinking.

Yet despite the differences I have just mentioned, I feel that I share many of the same cultural values and emotional patterns as first generation Russian-speaking Jewish immigrants. The family’s values I was raised with, such as highly valuing academic attainment, fine arts, and emotional privacy, and emotional authenticity, stem from the same cultural origins, and my secular form of Judaism is shared by many immigrants from the FSU. These shared values may helped me to relate to my participants and more quickly build rapport.

I am self-aware that I hold various assumptions about the pain and difficulty I associate with separating from a home country, adapting to a new culture, acquiring a second language, and possibly facing discrimination in the US of today. These assumptions may have, at points, created an image of immigrants as struggling and disadvantaged in my mind, and placed less emphasis on their strengths and assets as bicultural agents. I wrote memos about how these assumptions seemed to be surfacing, and I would return to the words of participants in order to ensure that whatever biases I held were not being inserted.

My previous research on immigration experiences, in which I collected original interview data in Miami, informed me of the strengths, resilience, and resources immigrants possess. I interviewed Latin American adolescents who migrated during their high school years and enrolled in GED programs, as well as adults from diverse cultural backgrounds who entered the US with doctorates, for two separate projects. From my experience conducting these projects, I developed an interest in formulating a dissertation project that explored the vocational psychology of immigrants. Both projects spoke to the ways that bilingual and bicultural experiences can be assets, enhancing cognitive resources and life skills. These projects also highlight how immigration experiences are distinctive from monolingual and monocultural existence.

Another aspect of culture that informs this project is gender. I have seen, both in research and through my clinical work and personal experience as a woman, how gendered messages about emotional expression impact people's lives. Female therapy clients often fear their own anger and assertiveness, perceiving themselves as "crazy" for having emotional responses to legitimate grievances. Meanwhile, my male clients express shame of vulnerability and sadness. Arlie Hochschild's use of "emotional labor" struck me as eloquent and timely in its description of how men and women are habitually judged differently, and given different sets of social and emotional tools to accomplish the same tasks. Given my own anecdotal observations about this concept, and my personal investment in it, I was especially attuned to any confirmation bias towards my preexisting assumptions as it emerges in my interview style. I allowed participants to speak for themselves on this topic, and when they did not observe any differing treatment based on their gender, I trusted in their experience.

Lastly, I have tried to examine how my disciplinary perspective as a psychologist influenced this project. Psychology plays a role in producing culture, especially the culture of emotions, as sociologist Eva Illouz (2008) observes. Psychotherapists “define emotional life as an object of management, control and regulation through specific techniques” (Illouz, Gilon, & Shachak, 2014, p. 226-227). Thus, as a practicing therapist, I contribute to the enforcement of the emotional norms I sought to study. In light of this, I found it especially important to use a qualitative method to capture participants’ own words for their experiences, rather than using the language of a prefabricated quantitative instrument with its own built-in system of valuation.

Traditional psychology has a tendency to focus on individuals with less regard for social systems. Over the past four years I have been a part of a community psychology research team, however, in which we examine individuals’ experiences in light of social and ecological context. I conducted this project with an eye to both the individual and the multi-layered systemic factors that influence internal experience.

In summary, I chose this topic out of a deep interest in intercultural exchange and a recognition of the importance of emotional labor in influencing individual emotional experience. I came to the topic with assumptions about the immigrant experience and gender roles, and with biases inherent to the field of psychology, which I attempted to bracket as I collected data. At all points, I tried my best to allow participants to speak for themselves.

Chapter 4: Results

In this chapter, I present the research findings of this study and discuss the process of data collection and analysis. In addition, I explain the themes and subthemes that emerged from the coding process and illustrate them with verbatim quotes from participants. Finally, I provide the composite description of the phenomenon derived from the data explication process.

Context

Setting and process of data collection

This study was completed over Zoom videoconferencing software between April and July of 2020. The interviews were not conducted in person due to the coronavirus pandemic and Centers for Disease Control and Prevention recommendations for social distancing to slow the spread of the virus. The lack of face-to-face contact during the data collection undoubtedly influenced the interview process, as it both allowed for the sampling of participants in diverse locations and limited the depth of personal involvement possible during the interviews. The pandemic also allowed for working professionals to have more free time to participate in the research.

Participant demographics

This study's participants were 10 Russian-speaking immigrants, consisting of 7 female and 3 male participants. They were from Russia, Ukraine, Moldova, and Uzbekistan. They ethnically self-identified as Jewish, Muslim, Ukrainian, Caucasian, and Russian. These men and women ranged from ages 24 to 66. The participants lived in cities across the United States, though most of them came from the Northeast, specifically New York.

Participants possessed a range of migration timelines, from just under a year in the United States to 30 years. They also had a variety of careers and education levels, though a majority of them had attended college. Participants were intentionally selected to represent a diversity of work roles in industries that required social interaction, from dance instruction to hospitality to sales to medicine.

Table 1: Participant Demographics

<i>Name*</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Race</i>	<i>Ethnicity</i>	<i>Country of origin</i>	<i>State of residence</i>
Annika	F	61	W	Jewish	Ukraine	Maryland
Maria	F	66	W	Jewish	Ukraine	New York
Svetlana	F	25	W	Muslim	Russia	New Jersey
Katarina	F	29	W	Ukrainian	Ukraine	North Carolina
Vlad	M	55	W	Jewish	Russia	Pennsylvania
Lana	F	48	W	Jewish	Moldova	Pennsylvania
Dasha	F	24	W	Russian	Russia	Texas
Peter	M	49	W	Jewish	Russia	New York
Natalia	F	35	W	Caucasian	Ukraine	Texas
Gabriel	M	45	W	Jewish	Uzbekistan	New York

Table 2: Participant migration timelines and work roles

<i>Name</i>	<i>Time in US</i>	<i>US job title</i>	<i>Country of origin job title</i>
Annika	30 years	Social worker	Radio broadcasting engineer
Maria	27 years	ESL teacher	ESL teacher
Svetlana	11 months	Dance instructor	Dance instructor
Katarina	8 years	Development & grants coordinator	Student
Vlad	29 years	Energy consultant & ski instructor	Geologist
Lana	28 years	Family physician	Medical assistant
Dasha	5 years	Hotel concierge	Assistant event coordinator
Peter	30 years	Sales manager	Teacher
Natalia	5 years	Realtor	Dentist
Gabriel	24 years	Nurse	Barber

Process of moving from codes to themes

My first step of data explication, and one I returned to throughout, was reading through the entirety of each transcript, slowing down and dwelling on the details of each narrative, and immersing myself in the world of the participant. This process proved increasingly important as I proceeded to subsequent steps of the data collection and explication, as I wanted to preserve the wholeness of my understanding of the phenomenon and revise my assumptions as I consolidated meaning from the data.

Preliminary meaning units were generated through isolating, naming, and describing each piece of data that revealed a feature or trait of the phenomenon of emotional labor experience. An example of this can be seen in the following statement

from Dasha describing her job: “Honestly it can be sometimes kind of exhausting because it requires a lot of emotional investment.” From this statement, two meaning units were derived: 1. feeling exhaustion from work; and 2. investing emotion into work. These preliminary meaning units were later clustered further into (1) feeling burnt out and (2) displaying certain emotions at work. Both of these clusters were then finally grouped into the theme of expectations of emotions at work.

Following this process of delineating meaning from the data and clustering and grouping units of meaning thematically, I produced a narrative of the experience of emotional labor for individual participants based on their interviews and the themes they contained. I then derived an overarching thematic horizon from which all themes emerged. Following this step, I was able to produce a composite description of the experience of emotional labor for my Russian-speaking immigrant participants.

Cultural context

Participants were drawn from a variety of contexts; six of them lived in areas with a concentration of other Russian-speakers, while five did not. Six ethnically self-identified as Jewish, one as Muslim, one as Caucasian, one as Russian, and one as Ukrainian (all self-identified racially as White). This diversity meant that participants described a wide range of experiences and relationships to both American and U.S.-based Russian-speaking culture.

Participants who identified as Jewish and arrived as refugees commonly described leaving the FSU due to a strong desire to escape Anti-Semitism. The ethnically Jewish participants described themselves as not feeling Russian, because as Jews they had been

excluded from the Russian nationality. Nonetheless, they did not identify with the Jewish religion, instead feeling Jewish “by blood only” (in Lana’s words).

Even those who were not refugees described corruption and inefficiency in their countries of origin that they were eager to get away from. Participants who did not arrive in the U.S. as refugees described coming for marriage to a person already living in the U.S., or in order to pursue US-based jobs. While participants describe difficulties associated with adjusting to a new lifestyle in the United States (for example, several complained about anxiety associated with needing to drive, especially during winter), the overwhelming feeling conveyed by participants was one of relief at successfully establishing themselves in the US.

All participants worked with a diverse mix of colleagues, and most worked outside of the Russian-speaking community. Participants related to other immigrants and the Russian-speaking community in different ways. Some very closely identified with the Russian-speaking community, and for this reason they chose to live in proximity to other Russian speakers and inhabit exclusively Russian-speaking social circles. Others made a deliberate choice to distance themselves from other Russian speakers and sought to assimilate as much as possible into English-speaking American spheres. For example, Lana described feeling that the expectations and distrust of Russian-speaking patients made her deliberately seek out an English-speaking office in which to work.

Participants expressed love and fondness for the US, and a belief in the idea that the United States was a land of opportunity, where anyone could accomplish anything with enough hard work. America was described as an “amazing, wonderful country” (Vlad) and gratitude towards the U.S. was a common sentiment.

Participants described the importance they placed on fitting into the US “mainstream.” This was particularly true for participants with children, who described wanting to live “immersed and surrounded by Americans” and have their children grow up indistinguishable from American peers and classmates. Katrina described wanting her son’s friends to see her as “just normal... So I tried to adjust to not hurt my son.” Annika described that “immigration is the sincerest form of flattery,” meaning that her choice to immigrate demonstrated that she highly valued the U.S. and all that it signified for her and her family. Annika consequently felt an obligation to assimilate in order to prove herself a useful part of US society. Natalia described a similar principle: “My point of view is, when you move to the country, you can bring your traditions. But you can’t bring your request that everyone act the way they’re supposed to act in Russia.” Similarly, Dasha shared a Russian proverb that she felt reflected her attitude towards cultural adjustment. The proverb roughly translated to “Don’t go to another monastery with your own set of rules.” She specifically identified this attitude as operating within her relationship with her American husband, who she was reluctant to make “uncomfortable” by imposing her Russian “habits” upon him.

Some participants did not have access to other Russian speakers at all, due to the location where they lived. Others arrived directly to a neighborhood with a concentration of Russian-speakers and settled there for many years. Still others, in their desire to assimilate, intentionally avoided other Russian speakers and focused on making friends with Americans. Several participants described arriving with other Russian speakers (family members), initially settling among other Russian speakers, and gradually moving into spaces with fewer Russian speakers as they acclimated to US life. Some participants

also described preserving a consistent, largely Russian-speaking social network for decades.

Several Russian-speaking Jewish participants described a unique antipathy towards their own ethnic community. Annika described that both she herself and many other Russian speaking immigrants felt a desire to run from other Russian speakers encountered in the street. She attributed this to living for so many years in a “country where, if you say something, it will be delivered to KGB, and you can lose your job, you can lose your life. There was a general mistrust which was cultivated by the establishment.” As a result, Russian speakers, and especially Russian-speaking Jews would feel “disgust with this situation that they were all in and now they would like to completely forget about that, that it ever happened” by disassociating themselves from the community once they had escaped the FSU.

While all participants shared the goal of fitting in, several participants also described a push to preserve aspects of their culture of origin, through language, religious observance, and teaching cultural values to their children. Preserving the use of the Russian language at home was particularly important for parents, who described feeling conflicted about their children’s Russian fluency. They wanted their children to assimilate and fit in well with U.S. peers, then found it hard for Russian to compete with the dominance of English language in their children’s lives. They expressed both pride and regret in the fact that their children were growing up “as Americans.”

Participants compared themselves to immigrants from different generations, distinguishing in particular the ways that their journeys and experiences were easier than in an older generation. Maria, who immigrated in the early 90s, described that she came

from a “typical Soviet family,” with a communal apartment shared by multiple families and two highly educated parents. Participants who did not grow up living in a communal apartment described themselves as “lucky” and not like others. Participants who arrived more recently reflected on the ease of communicating with family back home, in contrast to how difficult it must have been for immigrants in the 1970s. Other participants felt their adaptation process was easier to due sharing more values with Americans than other Russian-speaking immigrants, being more open to immersion in US culture, or receiving a warmer welcome than other waves of immigrants.

Findings

This phenomenological study asked the following two questions:

1. How do Russian-speaking immigrants in the U.S. experience emotional labor in their U.S. work settings?
2. How do cultural factors, including gender, affect this experience?

Results of this study yielded three superordinate themes across all 10 participants. The three themes were derived inductively from 1,515 initial units of meaning that were clustered into 17 meaning clusters, or subthemes. Once the unifying themes of these 17 subthemes were identified, I was able to summarize the full context, or horizon, from which these themes emerged (Moustakas, 1994). See Table 3 for full list of themes, subthemes, and exemplary quotes.

The horizon of the emotional labor experience for Russian-speaking immigrants was *the recalibration of expectations of social control, trust, and emotional performance* (abbreviated as *Recalibrating expectations*). This theme wove together workplace emotional adjustment with more general social and cultural adjustment to the United

States. The themes that emerged within the overarching theme of *Recalibrating expectations* were:

- 1) **Finding new individual freedoms alongside new social surveillance**
- 2) **Figuring out who to trust**
- 3) **Maintaining appropriate emotions at work**

These themes are representative of the entire group, with instances of individual-level differences as certain themes varied in salience for the lived experiences of different participants. Each theme, along with its component subthemes, will be explained in depth below and supported with quotes from participant interviews to illustrate the range of experiences captured. Special focus will be given to the way Russian-speaking immigrants' stories converged and diverged on these salient topics. The gender of participants also may have impacted their experiences in significant ways that will be highlighted in certain themes. The chapter concludes with a composite description of the experience of emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants in the U.S. A visual model of the themes can be seen in Figure 1. A full table of all themes, subthemes, and illustrative quotes can be found on page 69.

Figure 1: Visual Model of Themes

The recalibration of expectations of social control, trust, and emotional performance

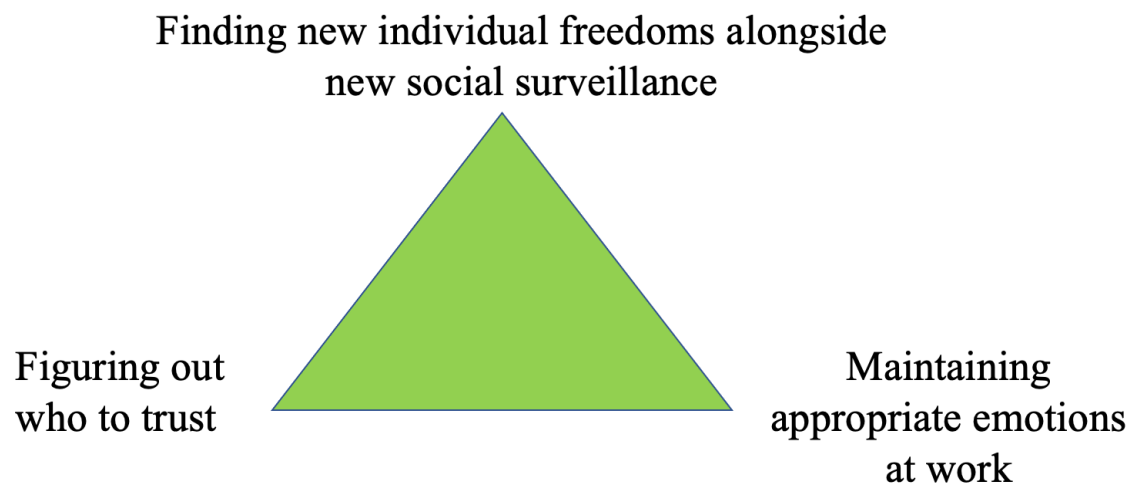


Table 3: Themes, subthemes & quotes

Themes	Subthemes	Quotes
<i>Finding new individual freedoms alongside new social surveillance</i>	<i>Feeling autonomous & independent at work</i>	“Being independent gives me chance, opportunity to, if I want to go somewhere. I like to travel a lot, and I do a lot. So I just need to think, plan my time little bit ahead. But I don't have to ask anybody if I can take five days or 10 days off my time. Just buy tickets, whatever, more convenient for me, and fly away. That's the great – the freedom. Freedom is, is a great thing. It comes with responsibilities, but it's awesome.” – Vlad “I love my schedule. For the last three months, I've been working from home. I know a lot of people lost their jobs. I'm still working, I still spend so much time with my son. There is no restriction. Like if I want to spend my day education, educating myself, no one is going to tell me anything... The freedom. I guess people trust me in my judgments, whatever. So I've really enjoyed that.” – Katarina
	<i>Scrutiny and regulation in the US workplace</i>	“Bloomberg started, you know, breaking the schools into smaller schools, and there were more administrators, more supervisors.” – Maria “I was on the floor. In the cubicle next to my manager. One manager. There was another guy that worked right next to me, another manager in her office... It's a big organization. Right. I understand that. It's, you know, it's a huge financial, it is still huge financial organization regulated by security commission and, and FINRA, and bunch of other stuff. So there's a huge amount of laws that they have to be compliant with.” – Vlad
	<i>Gendered freedoms</i>	“I figured out that I just cannot stay at home with a child. This is my way of parenthood. Hard for me. So I was looking for some opportunities to have a more flexible schedule.” – Natalia “Sometimes at home, you know, just, it was difficult. I had to spend a lot of time outside and I regretted, because sometimes my children needed me. But I had to go to work, or I had to take these classes or, you know, I had to do other stuff. And they needed me and I couldn't give them this time. And I regret it.” – Maria

		“When I got married, his family wanted to come here. So I wanted to be with him and I came with him.” – Lana
<i>Figuring out who to trust</i>	<i>Earning trust @ work, selling & convincing</i>	“It takes multiple approaches to get people to recognize me, myself and, and kinda like me well enough that they start listening” – Vlad “I learned over the years, there is what my mentor used to call it TLC: Trust, Love and Close. So, before you gain the trust and love from your clients, you won't get anything. You know, like, you won't be able to close.” – Natalia
	<i>Different relationships w/work colleagues</i>	“For me, colleagues is my colleagues here, right? In Ukraine. I probably would get together on the side, like, you know? Just, but here is just work is work. I didn't see, I didn't want to see them besides, my job.” – Natalia “ I would say my experience working back, working actually back in Russia, we were much closer with my coworkers... When I worked in a large corporate structure, it was a corporate culture and corporate structure that did not – there was no incentive for close relationships, for friendly relationships there.” – Vlad
	<i>New style of communication</i>	“In Russia first, very, very pushy. Like, you very hard and tough. You have to be, because if you are too soft, they not going to get results.” – Svetlana “In Russia, in the Soviet Union, it was very cut and dried. Do this. Do that. There was no ambiguous suggestive meaning in interactions. It was very direct. And that's what I used to follow. That was my background.” – Annika “Interviewer: Do you feel like in Russia, when you worked with people there, it was different? Dasha: You'll often hear direct feedback about your job. They would say ‘Hey, you are doing it wrong. This is how it's supposed to be done.’ Here, when you're doing something wrong, they're like “You're great, you're amazing, but, you know, I think that , I think that could be done differently potentially.” So you know, it’s not like directly, it’s like under all these layers of like “maybe, possibly, but you're so good.”
	<i>New attitudes towards authority</i>	“Physician in generally is a respected profession. And the same with teachers, much more respected in Russian than here.” – Lana

		“Students totally disrespect, absolutely disrespect education, school, teachers, everything. They didn't want to be there. They totally didn't want to be there.” – Maria “The people in power in the Soviet Union would never be willing to help, listen attentively, give you time of the day. They were waiting, by and large, for you to provide to them something significant like present. But not just present, it should be something, something of the right caliber of the present. People were expecting bribes in order to live there.” – Annika
	<i>New ways of interacting with strangers</i>	“When you are, ask American “How are you doing?” you get, “how are you?” in response. When you ask, “как ты” or how are you in Russia, get ready for a 30 minute conversation. Because that's, it's a question that needs to be answered, and then goes the story. If you didn't see the person for six months, you get the whole story of whole six months, important or unimportant things that did happen during that time period. And in America, it's a hello. “How are you doing,” it's a hello. And nobody answers.” – Vlad “You're just walking on the street and some smiling, and you're like, “Oh. What do you want?” For me, I mean, do I need to run now? I think like that. So, and the people talking on the street, and person just across, I mean, walking the opposite way. And you don't know this person, and this person can ask “How are you?” And you're like, [making uncomfortable expression] “Excuse me? Can I just continue go?” – Svetlana
	<i>Experiences of discrimination</i>	“They're like “Oh, are you here to intervene with elections? Are you Russian hacker? What are you?” – Dasha “They were like “Well, no, you immigrants just coming over to the country and taking over of our opportunities to work, our jobs.” – Natalia
<i>Maintaining appropriate emotions at work</i>	<i>Concealing certain emotions @ work</i>	“I cried a lot, actually. But I tried for people not to see” – Maria “In the beginning it was very hard for people to talk to me sometimes, and ask something, because I can get mad really quick. And that's first thing which I had to change.” – Svetlana
	<i>Displaying certain emotions @ work</i>	“You kinda have to pretend to be overly friendly to people, and be all like upbeat, all hyped up and just have this super bubbly personality and have to be overly excited about every little thing.” – Dasha

	“All my movements were calculated and I knew what I was doing, because I was rehearsing. But I was rehearsing something very dear to my heart that I wanted to be projected to them.” – Annika
<i>Controlling vulnerability @ work</i>	“They have to respect me. This was a problem actually. That they thought I am just like a puppy. But actually, I'm not.” – Svetlana “I would absolutely have to learn how to navigate, change, conceal emotions, so I will not become vulnerable. Because if people have knowledge of me, it means that I'm vulnerable.” – Annika
<i>Pushing away negative thoughts to cope</i>	“I didn't think about it needlessly. I needed to survive.” – Annika “I just try to ignore it as much as I can. Right? So, okay, it is what it is.” – Peter
<i>Calculating self-presentation at work</i>	“I had to change my clothes. But it was from Ross. And my goal was that it should look, little did they know, that it should have come Neiman Marcus. That was my goal. And they were, absolutely, for some reason, blown away by the way I would put my scarf, the way I would do my image. And I intuit, my intuition was telling me that that's, that's one of the things that I have to continue to do.” – Annika “Well I smile through, you know. I spent a lot of money on my teeth.” – Maria
<i>Feeling burnt out</i>	“I had to run from one place to another. Children and to college. By the time, you know, semester ends, then you just felt dead.” – Maria “Being emotionally invested into somebody, some other people, is quite tiring to me personally.” – Dasha
<i>Gendered expectations of emotions at work</i>	“I think with women, a lot of times it's feelings and emotions and, you know, with man, I think it's more direct again in a way where it's like, ‘Okay, let's talk numbers. Let's talk what can be done.’ With women, it's more, I think a little bit more of environment and, you know, and a little bit less of numbers and facts, and a little bit more of a conversation.” – Peter “I noticed that expectation from a female waiter is much higher. Hmm, you're, you're, you're expected to go above and beyond, and act like a mom, because you care <i>so much</i>.” – Dasha

The recalibration of expectations for social control, trust, and emotional performance

The essence of emotional labor for my Russian-speaking participants was a profound reckoning with their expectations of individual freedom and social surveillance, impacting interpersonal trust, their ability to openly express opinions and desires, and their performance and containment of specific emotions in work settings. Participants described certain emotions as appropriate for the US workplace, while others were not appropriate and should be masked, concealed, or otherwise worked against. In order to recalibrate their expectations, participants closely observed the behaviors and responses they received at work, learned what meaning to assign to these behaviors, and adjusted their own behaviors accordingly. The sense participants had to being supervised and monitored at work affected their ability to gauge trust in work settings, which in turn affected participants' self-presentation, display and concealment of emotions, and their subsequent energy expenditure at work, sometimes leading to burnout. In this context, participants experienced new freedoms at work in the U.S. alongside more scrutiny of their performance. Expectations placed on participants' emotions at work also affected how trustworthy they found their surroundings, and how free or controlled they felt at work. This interaction between all three superordinate themes can be seen in the visual model.

The sense of social control impacted the need to assess their surroundings for trustworthiness, which in turn influenced how participants learned to calibrate their emotions on the job, the need to change or conceal certain emotions at work, whether with clients or coworkers, in order to fit in with American expectations of which emotions are appropriate to a given workplace. Some participants described imitating the

behavior of American coworkers in order to adapt quickly, while others explained themselves to colleagues in order to smooth over differences. These findings suggest that it is difficult to disentangle the emotional labor of a Russian-speaking immigrant's work role from their more general process of adaptation to the social and emotional norms of the US.

I refer to the composite process of adaptation as a form of *recalibration*, in the sense that it required the gauging of external cues and modifying behaviors based on the information received from these cues. Svetlana described her adaptation to these differences as learning a new "pattern." "Even if you have it in your mind, you're not gonna do it right away. You're gonna have to realize and be aware, more. So you have to restructure your pattern."

Finding new individual freedoms alongside new social surveillance.

Within the context of recalibrating their expectations of who to trust, how open to be, and how to perform their emotions at work, participants found themselves confronted with a new set of freedoms and controls in their workplaces. Participants articulated a paradoxical tension between feelings of freedom and feelings of being controlled: while their US jobs granted them freedom and opportunities for autonomy that would have been unimaginable in the FSU, alongside this was a feeling that they worked under a level of regulation and scrutiny that did not exist in the FSU. The opportunities for advancement in the U.S. were accompanied by higher stakes for failure, leading to a greater feeling of being surveilled and monitored at work in the U.S. This monitoring encompassed how they were expected to express themselves and perform emotionally, as discussed in the other two themes in this chapter.

Feeling autonomous and independent at work.

Participants commonly expressed the value they placed on having autonomy in their professional roles, being able to make decisions for themselves, having a flexible schedule and allocating their time as they saw fit, and being independent. Some participants deliberately chose to work in fields that allowed for this type of freedom and flexibility, as in the case of Natalia who opted for a career as a realtor, while others sought to increase the amount of autonomy they had in whatever job they already occupied. Vlad described how he saw the opportunity to become more independent and self-sufficient as a result of the corporate restructuring that led to the loss of his long-standing IT job. He was able to become self-employed in an energy sales role that he described as inconceivable in the FSU. Katarina described how happy she felt when she realized her superiors valued her judgment and allowed her to do things at her own discretion.

Another aspect of this subtheme was the value participants placed on being able to achieve a balance between work and leisure at their own discretion. Several participants described loving to travel and valuing the ability to plan trips due to the structure and income provided by their jobs. Having control over how they spent their time, when they worked, and when they were able to relax was a priority for participants. This is why many of them had chosen to migrate to the U.S. in the first place, to better shape their careers and have access to opportunities unavailable in their nations of origin.

Scrutiny and regulation in the US workplace.

Participants described experiencing more regulation in their work lives in the US as compared to in their countries of origin. This limited their ability to feel trust in their

surroundings and openly express themselves at work. The feeling was that, while in nations of the FSU much of their work was either barely supervised or left to the lax discretion of local management, in the US more industries were tightly regulated and held to standardized expectations of quality and performance. These standardized expectations contrasted sharply with the more interpersonal, trust and friendship-based work relations that participants were used to, which I will expand upon in the next section.

One example of this impersonal scrutiny can be seen in Vlad's description of working in the IT department of a large corporation that required him to work alongside several layers of active supervisory management:

I was on the floor. In the cubicle next to my manager. One manager. There was another guy that worked right next to me, another manager in her office... It's a big organization. Right. I understand that. It's a huge financial organization regulated by security commission and FINRA, and bunch of other stuff. So there's a huge amount of laws that they have to be compliant with.

Policy changes issued from above would result in large shifts in daily life for participants at their jobs. In the case of public school teacher Maria, she described "Bloomberg started, you know, breaking the schools into smaller schools, and there were more administrators, more supervisors." Maria experienced this top-down regulation as incredibly stressful, as there was a disconnect between the lawmakers and the people, like her, who knew the realities of the work she was doing. She found that the work environment produced by these regulations was high pressure and inhospitable.

Gendered freedoms.

Expectations of freedom at work were impacted by the role that female participants tended to play in their families. Women discussed their husbands and children as major factors in their migration and career decision-making, at much greater length and depth than did male participants. Women tended to place their careers on hold after migration, in order to do what was necessary to secure their husbands' employment. Several participants described a subservient role for women in the FSU, especially in more rural communities, one that entailed taking on most housework, deferring to male partners for permission to do independent activities, and a prioritizing the man's career.

Female participants tended to play out these traditionally feminine roles, despite their high level of education and professional accomplishment. For example, one woman gave up her career as a dentist in Ukraine in order to move to the United States for her husband's job, eventually returning to work as a realtor instead. Another woman, a radio broadcast engineer, worked as a babysitter while her husband secured a new job in his field in the US. Once he had done so, she was able to pursue further education and become a social worker. This was considered a pragmatic choice, as men earned more. The side effect of the secondary status of women's careers was that women in this group described more unemployment and underemployment than men did post-migration.

Figuring out who to trust.

Participants described operating with a backdrop of extreme attention to issues of interpersonal trust. Their descriptions emphasized the importance of knowing who to trust, being perceived as trustworthy themselves, and learning how to interpret signals that people around them might be dishonest, fake, indifferent, or secretly aggressive.

Participants struggled to identify markers that American colleagues and friends truly cared about them, as there was a gap between how care was expressed between United States and FSU culture. At the same time, participants described adjusting to a friendlier yet more superficial set of interactions with strangers and acquaintances in the U.S., which they sometimes found harder to trust. They described being perceived as suspicious and untrustworthy themselves, due to discrimination they received based on their accent and nationality. They adapted to this discrimination by trying to change their accent and pronunciation, though often they ended up resigning themselves to their own accented speech. This theme profoundly implicated social communication.

As a part of translating the self into the English language and the American context, participants described needing to locate trusted people in the workplace to help with cultural misunderstandings. Not everyone would lend an understanding ear and offer gentle explanations. “Some of them can laugh at you,” Annika described. Participants often took a stance of trusting no one at first and waiting for those who would “prove themselves” trustworthy to emerge. Trust was thus never a given, but rather a continuously evolving element of the environment for each participant.

Earning trust at work, selling and convincing.

Participants found that many different work roles in the U.S. involved obtaining credibility from strangers and near strangers. The act of earning trust, selling, and convincing others to act in specific ways thus featured largely in their experiences at work. As Vlad, a former geologist turned energy salesperson, described:

First thing, have to sell yourself. People have to like you, before they open their ears to your product. And so, it takes multiple approaches to get people to recognize me, myself and, and kinda like me well enough that they start listening.

Vlad elaborated that sales involved a great deal of rejection, and he needed to develop a new emotional response to feeling rejected. He learned that “when you hear “No,” it doesn't mean you're a bad person. It just means person is not interested in what you have to offer. That's all." Thus, this theme involved developing a new type of trust in oneself as well as obtaining trust from others. He also described feeling that it was important to be "part of the society" of his customers in order to appear credible, find things in common with them, obtain an insider status and eventually sell to them. Vlad described needing to make multiple approaches before people will recognize him, begin to like him, and listen to him when he pitches his product. He would smile, compliment the business owners, and ask friendly questions to build rapport. Vlad also described a need to show familiarity with the neighborhood or local area, to convey a certain insider status. In some cases, he would need to make many approaches over months, receiving polite rejections all the while, before finally making a sale.

Both Vlad and Peter, a software sales manager, described the need to earn trust from potential customers by learning to speak with confidence about whatever area the sale pertained to, and learning how to set expectations for sellers and buyers. Vlad described that he needed to prepare a speech for sales visits, using local references, keeping it short to ensure he can finish before being "kicked out.”

In the case of Lana’s role as a family doctor, "you need to ask open-ended questions and very specific questions." Lana described that earning credibility from her

patients was key to her work. Annika described the need to walk a razor's edge as a social worker, being diplomatic in her guidance of other newly arriving immigrants and make suggestions without telling them they "have to" do anything. Annika also described the challenges of working with people from her own cultural and refugee background, requiring her to monitor herself for overidentification and prevent herself from showing anger or frustration when her clients would try to ingratiate themselves through gifts and bribes, as they were accustomed to doing in Soviet systems.

Katarina needed to ask donors for money in a way that seemed credible and not coercive. She felt reluctant because she would not want to be asked for money herself. Instead, she described that she would want to be inspired to donate by hearing about the great work of an organization. In an effort to treat donors as she would want to be treated, Katarina would not follow her fundraising script, opting instead to mention the name of the organization several times and describe the good work they were doing, without making a direct fundraising request. Echoing Katarina's sentiment that she treated people the way she herself would like to be treated, Natalia described a similar strategy in her interactions with home buyers as a realtor: "You know, some additional service, and just think of people and treat people the way I would like to be treated. Makes a huge difference."

Different relationships with work colleagues.

Participants described many barriers to building trusting relationships with people in the U.S. Participants described often finding Americans more private and less open than they proclaimed themselves to be. Americans who declared themselves friends did not act as available or forthcoming as Russian speakers expected of a friend. There was a

sense among participants that American manners and politeness came before honesty. Thus, in an effort to avoid conflict or hurt feelings, Americans were willing to lie. This sense combined unfavorably with the upbeat tendencies of American “small talk,” in which everyone responded positively to the question “how are you,” contributing to a sense of American fakeness or disingenuousness.

Svetlana described: "Here, people used to talk just about fun. And they don't want to talk about bad things. In Russia, it's opposite way." Katarina linked the American reluctance to disclose negative life events to Americans' fondness for psychotherapy: she felt that people in the United States need to pay a stranger to talk about their problems, because they're not comfortable confiding in friends. Katarina also shared a suspicion that Americans did indeed confide in their “super friends,” but she somehow was left out of this American inner circle. US friendships appeared mysterious and unknowable to her.

Participants found friendship to be of different quality in the FSU and among Russian speakers than what they perceived it to be in the U.S. They described a depth of confidence, emotional generosity, and reliability among Russian-speaking friends that they did not experience with Americans. This was also true of colleagues, who participants described as being more deeply friendly and connected to each other in the FSU than in the US, and more willing to perform acts of self-sacrifice on behalf of others. Participants described work friendships in the United States as superficial and brittle, often broken by small changes in job circumstances.

Participants conveyed that they had a hard time trusting American coworkers and Americans in general. They described feeling that there was a gap between what

Americans expressed and how they really felt. At the same time, participants described needing to rely on others for guidance at work. This subtheme involved the struggle of participants to seek out trustworthy social support and mentoring at work, and the difficulties they had blending friendship with working relationships in the US.

Work life was navigated through friendships, alliances, and knowing what was appropriate to disclose to who. Participants often relied on personal connections, through friends or acquaintances, to navigate systems at work and gain things professionally. This was how they were accustomed to functioning in the FSU, and it was a strategy they brought with them to the U.S. Maria illustrated the importance of friends and personal connections in several moments of her personal and professional life. When she first moved to Moscow, she did not have official government permission to live there, which was required at that time. Maria described how a friend helped her to find a place to live when she expressed fear that she would be expelled by authorities without an officially designated place of residence. Friends also pitched in to pay for her English teacher training course when she could not afford it by herself. Once in the United States, she continued to rely on friends to help her figure out her career. She met a fellow Russian-speaking immigrant who taught in the public schools.

I called her and I said, “you don't know me, but I want to meet you. And I want to be a teacher. And please just can you please tell me how it is?”

This person became a friend and mentor who walked Maria through the steps of qualifying as a public school teacher. Similarly, Katarina described how her friend of 8 years who became her boss offered her an opportunity that eventually turned into her full-time job:

My friend, my boss now, she said, “Hey, do you want to—” probably, she was like, “Man, that girl, like, have a potential, but she needs some help.” Right? So she asked me if I would like to volunteer for development department.

Participants repeatedly identified people in their environment, often other Russian-speaking immigrants, who proved helpful and trustworthy in guiding them towards career goals and opportunities for self-development and financial security. Given the distrust participants describe in their relationships with Americans, these dependable and instrumentally useful connections became exponentially more valuable.

The standard for trustworthiness and genuineness in friendship appeared to be quite high for participants. Annika suggested that life in a totalitarian society with a secret police force caused her to expect the possibility of informants among anyone, including friends and neighbors. This led her to develop “intuition” about who to trust. Participants may also have been especially attuned to questions of trust in the workplace due to a feeling they shared that work in the FSU was more oriented towards relationships.

Participants also needed to adjust to an absence of familiar expressions of care among their American peers. For example, most Americans saw no need to bring a gift or offer food when visiting each other’s homes. In many cases, American colleagues saw no need to invite participants into their homes at all. This represented a large gap between how care is expressed in United States compared to in Russia and the FSU. Participants often experienced this difference in custom as a lack of generosity on the part of Americans, and while they grew accustomed to it, several of them described deeply resenting this nonetheless. In Katarina’s words, despite the comparative dearth of

resources in the FSU, “in Ukraine, they would give the last thing they have in the fridge, and you would definitely have a cup of tea.”

Collaboration at work was also seen differently. Certain types of collaboration that were an acceptable part of work life in the FSU were punished as plagiarism or cheating in the U.S. Katarina shared that at university, in Ukraine, coursework felt more collective and collaborative than in the US, such that there was no concept equivalent to the strict standards of cheating or plagiarism at US colleges. As a result of this difference, Katarina experienced her U.S. classmates were strikingly unhelpful and self-interested, zealously guarding their work in contrast to the generosity of her Ukrainian peers.

Given the striking difference in the way people relate to each other in the FSU versus in the US, it follows that developing friendships with Americans may have proved challenging for participants. Several participants described feeling isolated, especially when they first came to the U.S. Some had trouble making friends, or experienced logistical limitations to meeting people who shared their background and language. Those who emigrated alone described not knowing anyone here and struggling to communicate in English, causing them to hold back in social situations. As they established themselves in the US, friendships and social networks consistently played an important role in their lives and heavily impacted their well-being. Russian-speaking friends allowed participants to relax among people with whom they felt they could truly be themselves, vent and receive supportive advice during times of stress, and in some cases even form an extended family or invest money together.

Maria described the reciprocity she found in friendship and the support she received from friends while going through her second divorce:

You do something for the friends, they do something for you. And they give me mostly the wonderful advice. For example, one of my friends, who's a celebrity in Moscow, when I was going through divorce, and it was really, really difficult for me. Difficult just, again, I cried every day, then she told me, "Listen now, you have to learn how to live single. And this is something to learn, and then you know you will, you would feel much better." And I thought about it and I learned how to do it. It wasn't easy, but then I learned how to do it.

While Maria was one of the participants who also described relying on psychotherapy to get through some of the hardships she experienced, it was clear from her account that friends were pivotal to her feelings of strength and resilience.

New style of communication.

Participants described a distinctive Russian style of communication. They described the Russian style as "tough," "pushy" or "pushing," and, above all, "direct." They described that, in Russia, people will tell you bluntly when they think you are wrong, whereas in the United States people will tell you with great hesitation, and only after receiving permission to correct you. A quote from Annika illustrates this:

In Russia, in the Soviet Union, it was very cut and dried. 'Do this. Do that.' There was no ambiguous suggestive meaning in interactions. It was very direct. And that's what I used to follow. That was my background.

Svetlana, a dance instructor, described the Russian attitude towards dance instruction as "I don't want you to love me. I want you to be successful." Svetlana and Maria both described feeling required to act in a harsh and pushy manner with students, even when they did not want to, in order to guarantee results. From their description, this demeanor

could be considered the display rules of Russian instruction, where a softer manner was disallowed.

This directness extended to the realm of relationships, where participants described that people in the FSU would frankly let you know their feelings towards you, whether like or dislike. There would be no ambiguity or false friendliness. In contrast, the style of communication that participants encountered in the United States was described as “sugarcoating,” with a great deal of attention paid to the feelings of the person receiving feedback. This indirectness was linked to conflict avoidance. Participants described that rather than confronting a person directly at work, American colleagues would prefer to go to a supervisor. Katarina described this approach as immature by Ukrainian standards (“like kids”).

Dasha described the American style of feedback as follows:

Here, when you're doing something wrong, they're like “You're great, you're amazing, but, you know, I think that, I think that could be done differently potentially.” So you know, it's not like directly, it's like under all these layers of like “maybe, possibly, but you're so good.”

Adjusting to this change in style required conscious effort from participants, as they felt they needed to learn to navigate “all these layers” to understand the feedback they were receiving. It also, to an extent, caused some participants to feel relief at not having to deal with the harsh criticism, yelling, and “attitude” of Russian bosses and supervisors. In Svetlana's words, Russians are “just not trained to be, engage what the other person feel.” Several participants described appreciating the sensitivity and desire to “inspire” that they experienced from US leadership at work.

In the process of adjusting to this new style of communication, some participants felt self-critical and perceived themselves as lacking in psychological sensitivity.

Svetlana described that she felt she had a bad attitude when she first arrived in the US, due to being reprimanded by her boss for her short temper and toughness. While this demeanor fit in well with the harsh and critical instruction methods she had been taught to employ in Russia, she came across as difficult in her new US work context. She described her learning process as follows:

Here in America you very into psychology things a lot. You know about it a lot from childhood. Your parents put it into you from childhood. In Russia, it's completely opposite way. And we have to learn it. Now. I have to learn it now. I have to pick it up quick.

New attitudes towards authority.

Participants experienced a new expectation that they would more easily trust authority in the U.S. This contrasted sharply with what participants described as the general Russian attitude of skepticism, distrust, and wariness towards being scammed in many contexts. This skepticism applied to the medical field, as Lana, a physician, described preferring to serve US patients rather than Russian speakers. She found that Russian-speaking patients were less compliant than US patients. She felt that the Russian community tended to more often rely on folk medicine or advice from their friends and felt this was partially explained by skepticism of authority figures and partly due to the fact that Russian speakers tended to be highly educated and thought they knew better than the doctors. Annika described that it was normal for Russian speakers to share their prescriptions with friends who reported similar medical problems, despite the dangers of

doing so. This was due to a greater trust placed in friends than in authority figures, medical professionals among them.

Adjusting their attitudes towards authority also involved learning a new set of behaviors. Several participants explained that Russian-speaking immigrants were accustomed to needing to bribe officials and service providers in order to get things done. Rampant and obvious corruption in the FSU was routinely navigated through bribes. In the US, participants found that the type of corruption they were used to was either absent or more concealed. This expectation had to be adjusted in the US, where bribery was generally neither expected nor accepted. Attempting to bribe a government official or anyone else in the United States would be seen as inappropriate and possibly illegal. Participants needed to learn to trust in these official systems and institutions to deliver promised services without the additional incentive of bribes.

New ways of interacting with strangers.

A widely discussed component of this adaptation process was the learning of new social norms, as the social habits of strangers in public were entirely different in the U.S. as compared to the FSU. These new habits helped to quickly telegraph trustworthiness and normality in public, and to diffuse any sense of suspicion participants might engender. One difference participants frequently touched on was smiling at strangers, a practice that was not common in the FSU. Annika described the conscious process she underwent to learn this practice.

Even though it was not part of my upbringing to smile when I encounter someone, I've learned how to do it. It was conscious learning. It was something that I set out to do. And I, I learned.

Another aspect of this adaptation process involved learning how to make casual “small talk,” conversations in which nothing much is said but friendliness and warmth is briefly conveyed, and smile at a wider array of people, including strangers, according to the customs of the US. These behaviors were a departure from the social norms in the former Soviet Union (FSU), and required conscious effort to learn. In Annika’s words, “when you learn to walk, you don’t remember the process. When you are thirty-something, you remember the process.”

In learning how to conduct “small talk” conversations, participants discovered that, while in Russian “how are you” is a genuine, caring question that expects a long detailed response, in the United States it is a greeting. Vlad described, “In America, it’s a hello. ‘How are you doing,’ it’s a hello. And nobody answers.” Vlad felt that the Russian response to this question incited more “genuine communication and friendly feelings,” while the American response tended to be meaningless and empty, creating no further connection. This difference in conversation style and content was a common observation shared by participants. As Annika described, “If they ask ‘how are you,’ it doesn’t mean that they need to know that your daughter is running a fever.”

Participants expressed that they were initially surprised when people in the United States would ask “how are you” and then leave before they had time to reply. Some participants felt that this indicated a lack of care for how they were actually doing. This can be observed as one of many small disconnects between how care is expressed in the FSU and how it is expressed in the US. However, not all participants shared Vlad’s preference for the Russian style; several participants enjoyed American “small talk” and experienced it as friendly, warm, and validating. For her part, Svetlana found that

sometimes in Russia conversations were “awkward and weird” because of the lack of small talk pleasantries. She described feeling strange at first when she began to learn these new conversational rules and needing to practice them many times before they felt more natural.

Svetlana called this learning a new “pattern.” “Even if you have it in your mind, you're not gonna do it right away. You're gonna have to realize and be aware, more. So you have to restructure your pattern.” Yet she grew to value this type of conversation. In her words, “this is cool. This feels good. This is full conversation.”

In connection with this, participants learned how to casually greet colleagues throughout the day, something they were not expected to do in the FSU. “I saw a person in an elevator in the morning and I said hello, or I was greeted, for me it meant that I said hello for the entire day,” Annika described. Yet at work in the US, she now had to learn to say hello whenever she saw a colleague in the hallway or bathroom, or else she would be perceived as rude.

Experiences of discrimination.

Participants described being doubted, suspected, and looked at askance due to their accent, ethnicity, and status as outsiders. They were sometimes treated differently, in ways they experienced as unfair. Maria struggled to convince people of her capacity as an English teacher due to her accent. Students mocked her accent and nationality, telling her to “go back to Russia,” while supervisors also expressed skepticism at her language abilities. Maria experienced the treatment she received as discriminatory when she compared it to how colleagues with Spanish-language accents were treated.

Maria was not alone in feeling ill-treated in this vein. Dasha described being taunted as a Russian hacker and asked if she was trying to interfere with the US elections when she first arrived in the United States in 2016. Annika described feeling condescended to by her US social worker colleagues who treated Russian immigrants like “children.” Katarina described feeling that people treated her with a negative attitude when they heard her accent, believing her to be stupid or unprofessional compared to US natives. Natalia described being accused of taking American jobs by men who attended her open houses; the hostility she experienced was so threatening that she stopped hosting open houses. Lana experienced mockery of her accent by colleagues.

Participants described feeling that they were perceived as less intelligent or less professional for having an accent. Katarina articulated her insecurity around her accent as follows:

Sometimes you wanna join the conversation and then you like, and then you ashamed of how you sound. You know, and you do want to be like professional and all, but that's, sometimes you have lack of words. And people see you probably as, as like stupid, you know. Like, if they hear an accent, you would assume that person is not smart, or something like that.

For Katarina, this hesitation to join conversations extended to a feeling that her ideas would be discounted, and her points would not be seen as valid. Several other participants shared this feeling that their lack of English skills negatively impacted their ability to be heard and do their jobs well. Katarina described overcoming some of these insecurities through the mentorship of her immediate supervisor and friend, who was also Ukrainian. This speaks to the importance of friends to working through issues of cultural adjustment.

Another way of coping with this differential treatment was through conscious effort to change their accents. Several participants considered taking accent reduction courses. One participant, ESL teacher Maria, did take an expensive accent coaching course in order to help address complaints from students and supervisors. Participants described that certain contexts felt more welcoming and easier to navigate with an accent. More diverse communities, places where people are “used to different accents,” and not “rude” towards speakers with accented English, were described as more ideal. Participants commonly described going through a process of eventual acceptance that they would always have an accent, but that this did not make them stupid or inferior thinkers, and often did not even interfere with their being understood.

Maintaining appropriate emotions at work.

Participants described that their jobs in the United States involved a level of emotive work that they were not accustomed to performing in the FSU. While the emotional labor participants described would need to be performed by anyone in these work roles, immigrant or native born, the absence of similar expectations or roles in the FSU contributed to the novelty and challenge participants found in this type of labor. This caused participants to contemplate and reconcile themselves to the gap between how they had been expected to act at work in the FSU and the expectations of their US workplaces. Participants described that they could not express themselves freely and genuinely without attending to the expectations that their colleagues and customers had of their emotional performance. Failure to attend to these expectations could result in workplace consequences ranging from gentle suggestions, to punitive actions and even being let go from a job.

This need to monitor and change emotions to meet expectations at work was related to the level of scrutiny and supervision each participant received from superiors; the more freedom and less scrutiny they received, generally the less pressure they felt to emotionally perform in this way. Similarly, the more trusting and close participants felt to work colleagues, the more genuinely they could express themselves on the job and the less they had to create emotional displays that did not fit their true feelings.

Concealing certain emotions at work.

Participants found that it was not acceptable to express certain emotions in their workplaces. These emotions included anger, frustration and sadness. Consequences of expressing these emotions ranged from subtle questions from clients and coworkers (e.g., “what’s wrong? Are you sick?”) to official reprimands and termination.

Maria described feeling upset but learning to conceal this from her students as a teacher. She needed to be patient and tolerant, despite feeling depressed, frustrated, and burnt out by end of semester. Maria reported “I cried a lot, actually. But I tried for people not to see.” She attempted to appear collected and happy to be doing her job. Maria found that this emotional concealment contributed to the stress of her job and affected her physical health; she eventually found herself taking sick days and missing work.

Svetlana described needing to both conceal and internally reshape her angry responses to coworkers in her dance studio. “In the beginning it was very hard for people to talk to me sometimes, and ask something, because I can get mad really quick. And that's first thing which I had to change.” She changed how she saw her colleagues, and allowed herself to feel more vulnerable and open towards them, in order to stop herself

from her frequent expressions of anger. Other emotions that participants reported concealing included nervousness, shyness, boredom, indifference, and dislike.

Another emotion that commonly needed to be concealed was nervousness or hesitancy. Both Annika and Katarina found themselves in roles where they had to exude confidence and suppress signs of nervousness. In Annika's case, she gave presentations about her immigration experience to donors in order to demonstrate that their contributions to the fund that brought her over from the FSU were being well-used. Katerina, similarly, needed to call donors to her non-profit organization and convince them to give more money. Despite feeling nervous about her accent and worrying that they might not understand her, she had to act *as if* she felt fully confident and competent in her role.

Displaying certain emotions at work.

Participants generally shared that neutral expressions were not acceptable in their work roles. They were instead expected to display specific emotions. Dasha offered a concise description of the emotional labor she was required to perform as a hotel receptionist and concierge:

You kinda have to pretend to be overly friendly to people, and be all like upbeat, all hyped up and just have this super bubbly personality and have to be overly excited about every little thing. So that's something that can be exhausting.

She did not have to act as "unnecessarily excited about things" as an intern event coordinator when she worked in Russia. She described the emotional expectations of that role as "just basic friendliness and politeness." According to Dasha's account, service workers in Russia do not try to be "super friendly" because "that's not what's

important...I think people just want to kind of like get whatever they came for... They don't really care about interaction with the person who provides the services."

When Dasha interacted with hotel guests, she described that "to them, being like in a neutral feeling, it's somewhat not appropriate." If she did wear a neutral expression in a service encounter, she found that American clients assumed she was unhappy or having a bad day. Dasha described the emotion-laden interactions with people at work as the most challenging part of her job. Dasha learned these customer service skills by watching her American coworkers and mimicking them. Similarly, Svetlana described that she had to emote more in conversations with clients in the US. In order to do so, she needed to "pull" these emotions from herself and perform them in American way. She described that this initially felt "weird," but with practice it became more natural.

New emotional display rules.

The differences in expectations of both emotional concealment and emotional display were mediated for participants by the different display rules that they observed in the U.S. as compared to the FSU (without naming them as such). Participants describe observing a difference in the way emotions are conveyed to others in the U.S. as compared to the FSU. In Svetlana's words:

Here you have to be very emotional. And if you see something cute, you have to be [loud cooing noises]. I not used to do this. I mean, this is weird to me. Yes, it's, and it really feels weird because you have to, like, pulling it from yourself when it's, it's hard. I mean, I feel it inside. I can say, say "oh yes, that's, that's so cute." But when you, it just feels unnatural.

In the FSU, participants found that more subdued expressions of positive feeling were accepted in public and among work colleagues, here they were expected to behave more effusively even when they did not genuinely feel like doing so.

This contrasted sharply with the expectation for negative emotional display. As described in the section on differences in communication style, while in the FSU it would be acceptable to directly express negative feelings, in the U.S. participants found that these negative feelings needed to be exceedingly softened or entirely concealed.

Controlling vulnerability at work.

As a byproduct of feeling a certain level of distrust for their surroundings, participants described a strong desire not to appear weak or allow coworkers to know information about them that would make them vulnerable to personal attack, criticism or incursions on their professional etiquette. They also observed a need to assert boundaries and standards for how they wanted to be treated by both clients and colleagues. This included learning how to maintain distance from others. Several participants described struggling to be respected as professionals in their field and needing to figure out how to gain this respect from others through trial and error of different behavioral strategies.

Annika described her role as a social worker in the Russian-speaking community as particularly challenging because “when someone who is within the community starts working in this community, it's detrimental to their success because people would never see you as a professional.” She felt vulnerable to being patronized and disrespected by fellow FSU immigrants, and so had to adopt an extremely professional and boundaried approach to her work. Similarly, Svetlana struggled at first to explain to her dance instruction students that she possessed expertise in dancing and had the right to tell them

what to do, rather than doing “everything this person want.” Svetlana described a similar need to set firm boundaries and emphasize her expertise in order to gain respect and feel less vulnerable to manipulation by both fellow staff and dance students.

Participants controlled their vulnerability in other ways as well. They concealed certain details of their personal information. Peter kept his colleagues on a strict information diet. “My family, my, you know, my marital status, my kids... a lot of times, people talk about that, but I try not to go into details,” Peter described. He also described avoiding sensitive topics such as politics, anything that his colleagues might get particularly opinionated about, because he did not want to share his own opinions. He did this in order to feel less vulnerable to personal attacks, argument and accusations of “political incorrectness.”

Participants also describe avoiding vulnerability by being assertive and not tolerating certain types of treatment. For Annika, she avoided overly personal treatment that some of her refugee clients tried to enforce with her by not mixing her personal and professional life, despite repeated insistence by her clients that she do so. She would not go to the parties, weddings, or other family gatherings they invited her to, and she would not offer them the shortcuts around official paperwork that they requested.

Pushing away negative thoughts to cope.

A popular method that participants employed in coping with the negative effects of their work roles and feelings of unfairness or exhaustion was to intentionally ignore these negative thoughts. In Annika’s words, “I didn’t think about it needlessly. I needed to survive.” Peter similarly reported that, in response to the looming threat of not meeting his sales quota and possibly losing his position, “I just try to ignore it as much as I can.

Right? So, okay, it is what it is.” This way of coping felt both effective and unobtrusive for participants, who often described a desire to blend in and not create problems at their places of work.

Calculating self-presentation at work.

Participants described a need to project credibility, trust, and insider status through a carefully calibrated self-presentation. described needing to dress and look a certain way at work in order to impress colleagues and make sure they looked professional. Annika reported

I had to change my clothes. But it was from Ross. And my goal was that it should look, little did they know, that it should have come Neiman Marcus. That was my goal. And they were, absolutely, for some reason, blown away by the way I would put my scarf, the way I would do my image. And I intuit, my intuition was telling me that that's, that's one of the things that I have to continue to do.

Similarly, Maria reported that she would smile through her difficulties at work and “I spent a lot of money on my teeth.” Several other participants, such as Natalia the realtor, Vlad the energy salesman, and Peter the software salesman, described a similar need to project a certain persona through deliberate aesthetic and visual choices: specifically, smiling and wearing a style of clothing familiar to their customer base. These aesthetic choices were not merely superficial, rather they ensured a level of respect that helped participants fulfill their work roles.

Feeling burnt out.

The effort of emotional performance at work did take a toll on participants. They sometimes could not prevent feelings of burnout or emotional exhaustion from affecting

them. Maria described “I had to run from one place to another. Children and to college. By the time, you know, semester ends, then you just felt dead.” Maria felt extremely burnt out and was eventually pressured into early retirement from her job teaching public school. Dasha reported that “being emotionally invested into somebody, some other people, is quite tiring to me personally.” When feeling this way, participants described seeking comfort and renewal from various sources – religion, physical exercise, friendship, and in Maria’s case, psychotherapy.

Gendered expectations of emotions at work.

Russian-speaking immigrants were not quick to identify gender as a factor in their own experiences. Few participants spoke spontaneously about gender roles or being treated differently at work because they were women, and it should be noted that when they were directly asked, participants often dismissed sexism as a possible explanation for their experiences. For example, Svetlana’s explanation of why she was treated differently than a male colleague hired at the same time was “different parents, different life situations, different everything. I mean, different background. Really different background.”

This likely speaks to the values and sensitivities of their Russian-speaking backgrounds. Participants were eager to perceive the United States as a fair meritocracy and were more apt to attribute mistreatment to their own personal failings. Yet gender did influence the types of challenges participants faced. Information gathered in follow-up interviews, as discussed in Chapter 3, particularly highlighted these challenges.

Gender impacted how participants were treated at work. Female participants shared feelings of being undermined and treated with less respect or credibility than they deserved. Lana, the family physician, described struggling to gain respect from certain

male patients. Natalia, a realtor, described experiencing xenophobic harassment from men at open houses. Svetlana reported being treated like “a puppy” rather than a seasoned and experienced dance instructor. She described that her male colleague, a Russian-speaking immigrant who arrived around the same time as her, was treated with more respect. As noted above, Svetlana did not believe they were treated differently due to their different genders.

Participants did observe differences in the way they were treated versus how their male colleagues were treated. These differences extended to the expectations placed on male versus female workers. Men were allowed to do their jobs without as much of an emotional performance, while women needed to persistently emote in exuberant and caring ways. In Dasha’s words, “I noticed that expectation from a female waiter is much higher. You’re expected to go above and beyond, and act like a mom, because you care *so much*.” Whereas, if Dasha were to perform more like a male waiter, she reported that “I feel like people would say that I probably didn’t care to provide service to them.” Likely consequent to these heavier emotional expectations, several female participants described feeling burnt out from the emotional demands of their jobs, while none of the male participants described this feeling.

One male participant, Peter, articulated an expectation that his female colleagues would be better at roles in which they were expected to make conversation with clients and show caring. Peter described “women are more skilled in sales related jobs or these types of services-oriented type of conversations” because they “are better conversationalists than men” and are more “process-oriented” and attentive to “the environment, and less to the numbers and facts.” This double standard suggested, as

Dasha observed, higher penalties for women who failed to convey caring, understanding and even flirtation, while men were not penalized for, in Peter's words, being "more results-oriented" and "more direct."

Female participants tended to place the responsibility for the way they were treated at work onto their own shoulders, describing changes it caused to their own behavior or internalized negative attitudes. For example, Annika described the need to assert strong boundaries and control the information her employers had about her, as failing to do so would cause them to judge her. Katarina, meanwhile, after feeling that her opinion was discounted in work meetings due to her accent and limited English vocabulary, described, "I feel like I don't deserve this job, for some reason. Maybe I have a low self-esteem or something."

Male participants seemed less inclined to beat themselves up for how they were treated, and more apt to accept themselves or describe their colleagues as flawed for misperceiving them. For example, in regards to having an accent, Gabriel said "I don't care. If you understand me, you understand me." Meanwhile, Peter described censoring himself at work because "I don't want to worry about being politically correct... All this American liberal stuff, I don't want to deal with."

This tendency in female participants to internalize and take responsibility for how they were treated, rather than viewing their treatment as structural or identity-based, fits in with a desire to assimilate to the cultural circumstances, as well as participants' cultural background, alongside a belief in America as a land of unlimited opportunity. As Vlad described, "we are very blessed in United States, that we have open systems and everybody can, if they, if they have a mind and hands and they can apply it together,

consistently, they can achieve anything. Literally limitless.” Gendered expectations thus appeared have an impact on participants’ work experiences, and to interact with participants’ enculturated attitudes and fantasies about the US, to produce specific impacts on participants’ levels of stress and self-esteem.

Composite description: The experience of emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants in the U.S.

Russian-speaking immigrants who come to the U.S. as adults and work in US jobs describe a process of recalibrating their expectations of social control, trust, and emotional performance that they bring with them from their countries of origin. The different types of social control and surveillance participants experience at work, as well as experiences of authority in the FSU, influence participants to pay particular attention to markers of interpersonal trust, care, and intimacy from their American colleagues, and place a high importance on forming trusting relationships, as well as trying convey their own trustworthiness and credibility. Their need to construct and interpret trust in their new situations leads to countervailing feelings of both being more scrutinized and monitored at work in the US, and being freer to shape their careers than in the FSU. Different expectations of emotional performance also feed feelings of interpersonal distrust, while making participants feel more surveilled for emotional responses appropriate to their US context.

The expectation that Russian-speaking immigrants display a new range of emotions at work, while concealing others, provokes both personal growth and self-doubt. Participants experience a need to control their vulnerability at work, by asserting boundaries, maintaining the privacy of their personal information, and at times insisting

on formality to help maintain their professional role. They earn trust and credibility from their colleagues, clients, and supervisors, by performing recognizable displays of friendliness, familiarity and care. They further learn to present themselves as attractive and put-together in order to gain trust.

Russian-speaking immigrants experience both freedom and the strictures of external control in their US jobs. They feel that they are able to attain occupational goals that are not possible in the FSU, earn more money, prestige, and respect than they previously had access to, yet they also feel heavily scrutinized and regulated by external bodies such as large corporations and state government agencies.

Participants describe the long and slow process of learning not just a new language but a new style of communication. They experience dramatic differences in how they are expected to interact with strangers. They learn to evoke a new gregariousness and friendliness in themselves, smiling at strangers, exchanging pleasantries, making “small talk,” and emoting more than they did in the FSU. These interactions feel especially effortful at the beginning of the migration experience, due to the language barrier they have to work against in order to be understood.

Russian-speaking immigrants register and adapt to the differences they encounter in their relationships with work colleagues. Their experiences often cause them to, at least initially, distrust the people around them and/or feel distrusted by them. Participants learn to communicate less directly, as they find they are expected to couch criticisms, opinions, and beliefs in softer language and sometimes simply contain their true opinions. Participants develop trust and friendship with select colleagues and use them as resources in navigating the cultural barriers of their workplaces. Cultural differences require

participants to adjust their behavior and expectations of authority, as they learn to expect more formal relations with government agencies. Doctors learn to expect more compliance from patients, while teachers learned to expect less respect from their students.

Russian-speaking immigrants describe learning to discern the true meaning behind what their American colleagues say. They describe devoting energy and attention to fitting in at work, grasping what their colleagues are trying to communicate, and discerning how they themselves are being perceived. Overall, Russian-speaking immigrants display a desire to assimilate and succeed in the American mainstream. They take pride in learning the nuances of their new work roles and excelling at them. Sometimes, participants feel ashamed and discriminated against in their U.S. workplaces due to their accents, their demeanor, or their nationality.

Russian-speaking immigrants often respond to criticisms of their language abilities and accent by internalizing these criticisms and trying to change themselves, via accent coaching, imitation of those around them, self-study, and sometimes by disassociating themselves from the Russian-speaking community. This last response is the most paradoxical, given how participants speak of the support and comfort they find in their Russian-speaking friends.

Negative internalization is particularly prominent among female Russian-speaking immigrants. Women are also particularly vulnerable to unemployment and underemployment due to family decision-making that prioritizes their male partner's careers. Russian-speaking female immigrants are prone to be treated with less respect than they deserved at work and be held to higher expectations in their performance of

caring, affective emotional labor in service roles. Russian-speaking immigrants often push away negative thoughts in order to cope at work. They describe sometimes feeling burnt out or emotionally exhausted.

An alertness to markers for interpersonal trust serves as a backdrop for the experiences of emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants at work. They must learn new social habits and patterns in order to fit in and thrive, learning new rules for openness and emotional performance. It is important to note the resilience and adaptability of this group. Despite experiencing burnout and pushing away their negative feelings to cope, they describe pride in their accomplishments and ultimate success. They credit their own resourcefulness for their successful adaptation to work, and present a high degree of self-efficacy.

Chapter 5: Discussion

The United States is a service economy staffed by millions of workers from all over the world. While certain trends in the US government persistently seek to downplay the tremendous benefits that the U.S. receives from immigrant labor, the truth is that this country could not function its best if not for the immigrants who contribute their talents, skills, and emotional labor to the economy. Without compassionate attention to the experiences and needs of our immigrant workforce, we risk ignoring and mistreating vital members of our society.

This study sought to better understand the emotional labor (EL) experiences of immigrants working in a culture other than the one in which they were raised. In this instance, I sought to understand the experiences of Russian-speaking immigrants from the former Soviet Union (FSU) through in-depth, semi-structured interviews. Findings were intended to augment existing research on EL and its effects, by uniquely focusing on the experiences of individuals performing EL in a culture other than their own. This study broke new ground in its deep qualitative examination of Russian-speaking immigrant experiences navigating multiple cultural influences while performing emotional labor at work in the United States. In this chapter, the study's conclusions will be summarized, as well as the study's limitations, theoretical and practical implications, and recommendations for future research, practice, and policy.

This study's findings identified common emotional experiences of Russian-speaking immigrant participants in the US workplace across their varied backgrounds and work roles. Their process of adjustment to US social norms and to specific US work environments creates additional EL tasks, above and beyond the EL tasks they perform

that have been previously found in the literature. This process involves the adaptation to US emotional display rules and a search for trustworthy social supports. Below I will give an overview of findings and how they fit into previous findings on emotional labor, discuss the study's limitations, review the theoretical implications and practical implications of the study, and give recommendations for future research, practice and policy in accordance with the findings.

Overview of findings

The findings of this study indicated that participants described *the recalibration of expectations of social control, trust, and emotional performance* as essential to their experience of emotional labor in the United States. Salient themes within this experience were as follows: finding new individual freedoms alongside new social surveillance, figuring out who to trust, and maintaining appropriate emotions at work.

The discrete behaviors that participants described as being a part of their emotional labor performance were consistent with previous research: concealing certain emotions (Constanti & Gibbs, 2004; Grandey & Melloy, 2017; Pizam & Shani, 2009; Trougakos et al., 2011), displaying certain emotions (Adelmann, 2004; Deshotels & Forsyth, 2006), and learning new emotional display rules (Yanchus et al., 2010). Findings also indicated that controlling self-presentation and the feeling of vulnerability were important factors in participant experiences of emotional labor. This is an innovative finding, as it indicates new dimensions that EL touches upon when interacting across cultures.

Previous research on emotional labor within native-born populations working in their own culture has displayed robust links between EL, particularly surface acting, and

emotional dissonance, emotional exhaustion, lower performance and burnout (Yanchus et al., 2010). Deep acting, in contrast, has been less associated with strain and positively associated with job enrichment and life satisfaction (Grandey et al., 2005; Yanchus et al., 2010). This project was done in this unique context of immigrants from a different cultural context performing emotional labor in the U.S. Like prior research, this project elucidated a relationship between emotional labor and job stress. Unlike prior research, this project used in-depth qualitative data from immigrant participants to describe several specific stressors they found salient to their performance of emotional labor, namely the role that social surveillance at work and interpersonal trust had on their emotional performance.

While cross-cultural studies of emotional labor have been limited, this study's findings are consistent in distinguishing the experience of US nationals and non-US nationals. Allen, Diefendorff, and Ma (2013) found a weaker relationship between emotional labor and burnout in Chinese service workers as compared to US service workers. Allen et al. concluded that Confucian cultural values influenced these outcomes, as they placed less emphasis on autonomy and emotional authenticity than the cultural values of the U.S. In this same vein, the Russian-speaking participants in this study appeared to place a high value on emotional authenticity and sincerity, causing emotional labor to feel notably effortful and taxing. In accordance with this finding, Grandey, Foo, Groth & Goodwin (2012) found that a "climate of authenticity" in the workplace, in which organizational members are more accepting of displays of different emotions, discourages burn out. Authenticity was a major thread running through the themes that

describe the experience of emotional labor for Russian-speaking immigrants, as I will expand upon below.

Social control at work

In order to understand the EL of the Russian-speaking participants, it is important to understand their perception of their work context. Participants described feeling scrutinized and monitored by both colleagues and supervisors throughout their work life. The effect of social surveillance in the workplace has been researched in terms of performance monitoring, which is related but not identical to the type of social control described by participants of this study. Prior research on workplace surveillance has found that extensive employee monitoring and evaluation is a “taken-for-granted element of working life” in the U.S., which can nonetheless negatively impact employee well-being, productivity, creativity and motivation when there is a gap between employee expectations and organizational practices (Ball, 2010, p. 89).

Holman, Chissick & Totterdell (2002) found that the perceived intensity of performance monitoring was related to increased levels of emotional exhaustion and reduced well-being for employees. Kinnie, Hutchinson & Purcell (2000) also found that a “panopticon” approach of constant monitoring produced burnout, decreased job satisfaction and encouraged high employee turnover. This suggests that surveillance of employees strongly impacts how people feel at work.

Consistent with previous research, the findings of this study described negative experiences with control and monitoring at work, and a contrastingly positive effect when participants experienced high job autonomy that made emotional labor more manageable. Participants consistently described facing a higher level of scrutiny at their jobs in the

U.S. than they were used to in the FSU, causing them to feel wary and on guard. Intrusive top-down management was experienced as highly stressful and discouraging of camaraderie and authenticity in the workplace. Meanwhile, the increased ability to shape their careers and regulate their time off was experienced as a major reason why participants endorsed their choice to migrate to the U.S. Being self-employed, in particular, was seen as a uniquely American opportunity for autonomy that would have been close to unattainable in the FSU.

Trust at work

Previous research on emotional labor has not emphasized the role of interpersonal trust at work. Research has instead focused on organizational trust (e.g. Cho & Song, 2017). Grandey, Foo, Groth & Goodwin (2012) found that a “climate of authenticity,” characterized by an organization that encourages and supports authentic emotional expressions within the group, alleviates emotional labor burdens and reduces burnout. This sort of climate has less constrained emotional display rules and a higher level of “psychological safety,” in which team members are not afraid of being embarrassed, rejected or punished for speaking up for themselves. Similarly, Cho & Song (2017) found that lower organizational trust led to higher employee turnover, suggesting that organizational trust is an important factor in employee’s enjoyment of their workplace and desire to stay.

The concept of a climate of authenticity is related to the findings of this study, which describe the high importance participants placed on knowing who to trust, being perceived as trustworthy themselves, and learning how to interpret signals that people around them might be dishonest, fake, indifferent, or secretly aggressive. However,

participants notably described that they did not perceive that their organizations had a climate of authenticity. In fact, participants felt that their workplaces were tricky to navigate for the very reason that authenticity was not encouraged and the specific expectations and demands of US colleagues were counterintuitive and often difficult to discern for cultural outsiders like themselves.

Participants described experiences of discrimination and mockery due to their accent and nationality, further contributing to their overall sense that they were often navigating treacherous waters and thus needed to pay special attention to trust in the workplace. This contributed to the challenge of emotional labor performance, consistent with Grandey et al. (2012)'s findings that a workplace climate that does not promote authenticity can increase emotional exhaustion and burnout.

Russian-speaking immigrant work adjustment

Russian-speaking immigrants defy neat cultural categories in many ways. As discussed in the review of literature, the FSU is made up of hundreds of nationalities and ethnicities spanning a huge geographical area. Cultures have been described as either collectivistic (non-competitive and mutually cooperative), or individualistic (conceiving of themselves as separate from others and defining their goals independently) (Triandis, 1988). According to Hofstede's (2001) cultural values, Russia is much more collectivistic than the U.S. Yet the participants in this study display a mix of both of these values. They conveyed competitiveness and interdependence in their self-descriptions, striving for autonomy and freedom while relying upon relationships and trusted social networks.

Participants described a paradoxical tension between the increased freedoms offered by employment in the US economy, and the tighter supervisory scrutiny they felt

while at work. This observation has not previously been recorded in research on emotional labor, and thus can be seen as a novel contribution to the literature. The gap between their expectations of work, derived from FSU practices, and what they encountered in the US might explain why Russian-speaking participants found the new scrutiny they faced in their US work roles especially impactful.

Given previous research on emotional acculturation (De Leersnyder et al., 2011), and the contrast between emotional display rules in the United States and in the former Soviet Union (FSU) (Humphrey, 2018; Kryz et al., 2016), I anticipated that my participants would experience unique adjustment challenges when performing EL in US workplaces. This proved to be a common experience for participants, who reported discontinuities between the US and FSU, and a need to consciously learn how to emote and maintain appropriate emotions in accordance with US expectations. This cultural learning process was associated with feelings of disconnection and mistrust.

Participants encountered challenges in trusting and communicating with their US colleagues. They expressed a very high bar of trust that had to be met in order to consider a person a friend, and they did describe that they felt a lack of competence in gauging the true friendship intentions of American peers. This finding accords with ethnographies of Russian-speaking immigrants, which have observed a tendency to value trust and emotional authenticity, a tight inner circle, a strong alliance to the extended family, and a reserved display of public emotion (Markowitz, 1993; Markowitz, 1994; Gold, 1992).

An emphasis on interpersonal trust contributed to the emotional tax Russian-speaking immigrant participants experienced in the workplace. This tax, as discussed in Chapter 2, is the need to protect oneself from unfair treatment that marginalized groups

experience in the workplace (Travis & Thorpe-Moscon, 2019). The need to decipher who to trust at work can be seen as an additional burden within the pre-existing EL requirements of any given workplace. Further contributing to the emotional tax participants experienced was the discrimination they described in their US workplaces. This discrimination was primarily related to their accents and being identified as Russian, an entity that engaged the cultural imagination of their American colleagues. Castaneda et al. (2015) found similarly that discrimination against Russian migrants in Finland was associated with decreased trust towards society and reduced feelings of safety.

When the bar of trust was met within relationships, Russian-speaking participants flourished. Participants derived a great deal of tangible support, emotional connection, and common cultural references that alleviated social isolation from their Russian-speaking social networks. This is consistent with ethnographic research on a Russian-speaking migrant community in London by Malyutina (2018), which found that the Russian-speaking community provided its members with support and empowerment that helped them confront feelings of being marginalized in UK society.

Another reason why interpersonal trust was so salient was the Russian cultural expectation that informal connections and bribery, known as *blat* (Jurcik, Chentsova-Dutton, Solopieieva-Jurcikova & Ryder, 2013), could be used to advance through bureaucratic and formal organizational processes. This was an expectation that needed to be adjusted to the realities of how things work in their new surroundings. While some forms of *blat*, such as bribery, are considered inappropriate or even illegal in the United States, pulling on existing connections in order to secure information and jobs often did serve to help participants accomplish their goals.

As in prior research on the connection between surface acting and burnout (Mesmer-Magnus, DeChurch, & Wax, 2012; Hülshager & Schewe, 2011; Kammeyer-Mueller et al., 2011), participants described that it was especially taxing to perform emotions that they did not genuinely feel. Some participants explicitly linked these performances to a deterioration in both their mental and physical health.

Gendered expectations

Gendered expectations appeared to impact the types of experiences participants described. Female participants often reported sidelining their own careers in order to take care of children and/or prioritize their husband's careers, leading to greater underemployment and unemployment for women in this group. This was not described as a conscious choice, but rather a default reality. Likewise, women participants described challenges to their authority and professionalism, higher expectations of warm exuberant emotional displays compared to what was expected of male colleagues, and feelings of burnout. This finding is consistent with previous research that women are significantly more likely to bear higher emotional labor burdens than men even when sharing the same job roles (Cottingham, Erickson, & Diefendorff, 2015; Erickson, 2004; Gray, 2010; Meier, Mastracci, & Wilson, 2006; Morris & Feldman, 1996; Polleta & Tufail, 2016; Simpson & Stroh, 2004), and that women are found to experience more negative effects from emotional labor (Johnson & Spector, 2007; Han et al., 2018; Wang, Huang, Yin, & Ke, 2018; Walsh & Bartikowski, 2013). It is also consistent with research on migration and mental health reviewed by Alegría, Álvarez & DiMarzio (2017), which found that men, individuals who had immigrated at a younger age, and individuals who had spent more time in the USA displayed fewer mental health symptoms as compared to women,

individuals who immigrated later in life, and individuals who had immigrated more recently.

Female participants often seemed to internalize responsibility for how they were treated, for example, feeling that they did not deserve their job or that they had a bad attitude, and sought to change themselves in order to smooth over their work difficulties. Male participants, in contrast, tended to attribute their difficulties to external factors. Participants did not spontaneously attribute unequal treatment of men and women to sexism or systemic unfairness, and were particularly reluctant to describe the US as a discriminatory place. This was particularly revealed in follow-up interviews.

This can be explained by an absence of feminist consciousness in the cultural background of many Russian-speaking immigrants. Gray (1991) clarifies that there was no women's movement in the nations of the FSU. While women in the Soviet Union were encouraged to seek education and work outside the home, they were simultaneously encouraged to bear children and engage in traditional female homemaking responsibilities (Gray, 1991; Jurcik et al., 2013). Thus, female participants' dismissal of sexism and tendency to internalize responsibility for poor treatment fits with the ethos of their cultures of origin. In addition, participants' reluctance to label the US negatively may also be connected to their strong belief in the American dream of absolute meritocracy and unlimited opportunity, and a desire to frame their new country in generally positive contrast to the FSU. Both of these factors may have encouraged participants to ignore how gender influences their treatment.

Limitations

While this study highlighted salient aspects of participants' experiences of emotional and social demands in their US workplaces, there were notable limitations on the data. An effort was made to recruit a sample that was roughly gender equal, more women ended up volunteering to participate, and the final group of participants was made up of mostly women. Future studies might seek to sample a wider array of male participants to investigate a greater range of their experiences. In addition, future studies might seek to explore the experiences of transgender and gender non-conforming individuals who would not be classified as either male or female, in order to elucidate which of their experiences resemble the experiences reported in the findings, and which diverge.

Participants responded to my own identity as the researcher. For example, several participants attempted to speak Russian with me, a language that I do not speak. Who knows how responses might have changed, had I been able to respond in Russian. Prior qualitative research has found an increased level of trust when a common language is shared, in the case of Spanish-speaking Mexican-American nursing patients (Jones, 2018).

Due to the special circumstance of the coronavirus pandemic during the time of data collection, all interviews were conducted online via video conferencing software. This method allowed for geographic diversity in sampling, but it also affected the level of intimacy that could be established with participants. Participants did not always have complete privacy when speaking with me, as I would have been able to guarantee for us in person. This may have affected what participants chose to disclose.

Fifthly, all participants identified racially as White, and a majority identified ethnically as Jewish. While this was anticipated, given the demographics of Russian-speaking immigration to the United States, the sample for this project does not represent many of the ethnic groups of the FSU, who may have very different experiences than the participants of this study.

Theoretical Implications

Findings from this study have theoretical implications on the research of emotional labor, research of acculturation processes, and how these two bodies of research interrelate. According to Barbara Rogoff (2003), culture is defined by a community's routine traditions and practices. While Russian-speaking immigrants began life in the FSU, they later joined new communities in the U.S., both within ethnic enclaves and within a largely English-speaking American milieu. In order to participate in these communities, this group needed to acquire what Agar (2006) terms languaculture, "all manner of background knowledge and local information in addition to grammar and vocabulary" (p. 2). Emotional labor (Hochschild, 2013), with its display norms that vary by organizational context, could be seen as one aspect of languaculture; EL essentially dictate the appropriateness and connotation of speech in many work contexts. Findings indicate that the acculturation process and the general languaculture learning process compound the difficulty of EL performance described by participants.

While findings indicate that EL is made more complex by acculturation, findings also suggest that a form of EL is embedded in the process of acculturation itself. Approximations of both deep acting and surface acting play a role in the acculturation process. As immigrants adopt the emotional display rules of their new culture, their

behavior mimics the EL of a worker at a job with specific display rules. From participant descriptions, it appears that immigrants followed one or a combination of two approaches: 1. imitating the behavior of those around them, despite finding this behavior strange or foreign (surface acting); and 2. internalizing American values and thus finding a genuine motivation to act like an American (deep acting).

Molinsky (2013) came to a similar conclusion about the methods underlying cultural adaptation, which he referred to as “cultural retooling” (p. 683). He labeled the two approaches he found in his research as 1) “instrumental,” equivalent to surface acting, in which individuals “achieve task performance by forcing themselves to perform the offending behavior despite the internal conflict it generates”; and “integrative,” equivalent to deep acting, in which individuals find “a way to feel authentic performing this behavior that, at least initially, poses an intense conflict with their ingrained cultural values and beliefs” (p. 685). The distinction between identity and behavior within the acculturation process made by Birman & Simon (2014) can also be mapped on to the distinction between deep and surface acting; deep acting is equivalent to the identification with a culture, while surface acting can be seen as adopting the behaviors of a culture without identification.

This interpretation of acculturation through the lens of EL suggests interesting relationships between both conscious and unconscious methods of acculturation and their possible outcomes. If deep acting and surface acting in acculturation function similarly to findings on emotional labor at work, it would suggest that surface acting, “instrumental,” or “behavioral” approaches might have more negative effects on well-being than deep acting, “integrative,” or “identification” approaches. This also helps explain why

participants tended to keenly profess a belief in the American dream, as this adoption of US values would be a form of deep acting or cultural identification that would make adhering to US emotional display rules feel less onerous and unnatural.

Findings demonstrated a significant tendency towards interpersonal distrust among Russian-speaking immigrant participants. Matthew Carey's hypothesis of mistrust (2017) posits that societies with pervasive general attitudes of mistrust are predicated on "a philosophy of rugged autonomy and moral equality that assumes other people to be both free and fundamentally uncontrollable" (p. 10). The refusal to trust another person, in this view, is also a denial of one's capacity to predict another person's behavior and subsequently rely on that prediction.

This hypothesis fits particularly well in light of two aspects of the culture of Russian-speaking immigrant participants. First, participants described reacting to the totalitarian Soviet state with a countervailing drive towards complete autonomy and independence. This reaction also helps describe the tendency of participants to ardently believe in America as a meritocracy, in contrast to a Marxist understanding of the US as an oppressive and exploitative capitalist system. Yet, when this drive towards ultimate freedom is projected onto others, it would produce the unknowability that Carey refers to as grounds for general mistrust.

The second cultural aspect that appears to fit Carey's hypothesis is the gap between how care is expressed in the FSU and how care is expressed in the US. Gestures of hospitality, such as sharing gifts and food, are much less common in daily encounters in the US than they are in the FSU. Routine conversations in the US are less likely to include intimate disclosures and genuine responses to the omnipresent US greeting, "how

are you doing?” People in the US are less likely to directly indicate their feelings, if they believe it might lead to confrontation. These differences accumulate towards a feeling, in Russian-speaking immigrants, that true US affection is hard to recognize, even among people they see regularly, and thus “familiarity is insufficient ground for trust” (Carey, 2017, p.8). If American hearts appear unknowable and radically free to Russian-speaking immigrants, a general stance of trusting no one makes sense for daily life.

Practical Implications

This study produced three key practical implications for counseling psychologists and other mental healthcare providers to consider when working with Russian-speaking immigrant clients: (1) the process of social and emotional adaptation to a new culture can blend with existing workplace emotional demands to increase feelings of guilt, self-blame, and low self-esteem; (2) Russian-speaking immigrants are slow to trust strangers and authorities, and reluctant to share personal information until they develop trust; and (3) a sense of autonomy at work influences positive feelings towards their jobs. While these findings have practical implications for providing care to this group, it is always important to attend to the individual needs and experiences of a Russian-speaking immigrant client that may not conform to these findings.

The blending of cultural adaptation and emotional labor

The findings of this study suggest that, for Russian-speaking immigrants, the stressors of certain work roles blend with the acculturative stress associated with cultural adaptation, enhancing the total stress experienced from even simple daily tasks and conversations in the workplace. These multiple superimposed stressors appear to augment overall feelings of burnout, especially when experienced alongside an attitude of

personal responsibility for problem-solving all difficulties, an attitude that was prevalent among participants. While this attitude appears to be motivating, since it encourages hard work to overcome obstacles, in some cases it can increase feelings of guilt, self-blame, and low self-esteem in the face of work stress.

Developing trust with Russian-speaking immigrants

Findings suggest that Russian-speaking immigrants, as a group, are slow to develop trust, and require a high level of genuineness and authenticity to feel comfortable. Participants discussed a skepticism towards authority, including the medical establishment. Findings also indicate that the trust and confidence of friends, especially fellow Russian speakers, was highly important for the social support it provided, including mutual understanding, advice, and material help in times of need. Participants reported secure, longstanding friendships of many decades with fellow immigrants. Thus, while trust was not universally granted or immediately forthcoming in this group, those who were trusted were valuable resources for Russian-speaking immigrants' mental health and well-being.

The positive impact of autonomy at work

Feeling autonomous and empowered at work had a large impact on how happy participants were with their jobs, creating avenues for positive experiences and increased self-esteem. Findings also spoke to the challenges specific to female immigrants in accomplishing career goals, such as unemployment and underemployment due to family obligations, difficulty securing respect and credibility in their professions, and high expectations of emotional labor performance. Female participants also described

internalizing negative ideas about themselves after experiencing disrespect or discrimination at work.

Recommendations for practice

The findings of this study suggest that Russian-speaking immigrant clients should be treated by clinicians competent in understanding this group, with special attention to why they might be skeptical of the medical establishment and more apt to follow the advice of trusted friends. In working with this group, it may be important to attend to these multiple overlapping pressures that could contribute to negative mental health outcomes. It may also be consequential to understand the emotional tax, as mentioned above, that Russian-speaking immigrants pay at work. It is imperative that, in order to develop a trusting relationship with this population, a clinician must first come to empathize with the reasons trust might not be forthcoming. Developing trust with this group may take time, especially for cultural outsiders. For this reason, long-term therapy seems preferable for this group, to allow the time to develop a strong therapeutic alliance and trusting rapport. There may be value in connecting Russian-speaking immigrants to other individuals from the same background with more experience in the United States, perhaps in the form of mentors or support groups. In doing so, clinicians can empower Russian-speaking immigrants to help themselves and each other in culturally congruent ways.

Russian-speaking immigrants experience a gap between how they expect people to behave and what is actually going on around them in the US. In practice, this means that Russian-speaking immigrants should not be interpreted as paranoid, uncooperative, noncompliant, or unsociable for behaving in culturally legible ways that may appear

discordant to a US practitioner. As in all culturally competent practice, Russian-speaking immigrants should be understood within their cultural context. For clinicians hoping to facilitate trust, self-disclosure might prove essential to developing feelings of familiarity and safety with these clients. Genuineness, an absence of euphemistic clinical language, and collaboration to find culturally congruent analogies for treatment goals may also aid in rapport-building and increase feelings of open communication between client and therapist.

Given how centrally career accomplishments factored into participants' feelings of self-esteem and life meaning, it is important to promote vocational accomplishment in Russian-speaking immigrants. This includes helping to empower them to find feasible paths to accomplish existing career goals, as well as helping them to establish new careers in the face of obstacles to employment in their original field (e.g., difficulty transferring credentials and lack of recognition for previous education). Providing these resources in their native language would be a particularly effective method of empowering this group towards a sense of accomplishment and self-efficacy.

The specific challenges faced by female Russian-speaking immigrants, such as a family prioritization of the husband's career, may make it more difficult for women of this group to attain full employment commensurate with their skills and abilities. It is important for counseling professionals to keep these gender-specific experiences in mind and be able to contextualize them when performing vocational counseling with this group. It is especially important to maintain a cultural sensitivity to the attitudes of Russian-speaking immigrant women, who may not be sensitized to sexism, while also

encouraging them not to internalize negative self-beliefs in response to gender discrimination in their workplaces.

In order to foster engagement with mental wellness, it may be important to work outside of the traditional confines of the therapist's office and provide opportunities for engagement in the community. For example, Russian-language anxiety and stress management workshops that attend to the specific stressors this group experiences could be held in familiar and non-threatening community locations, such as restaurants or coffee shops. Guides for self-care and coping with cultural adjustment could be distributed in Russian supermarkets or other neutral locations, where the information may have a normalizing effect on those coping with stress. Likewise, clinical interventions could incorporate referrals to language classes or community events where a client might be likely to connect with immigrant peers.

Developing deeper connections to a Russian-speaking community could help immigrants to build social support systems and empower themselves through sharing common experiences. Given the strong role of friends as social supports, group interventions may be helpful, though the mistrust of strangers and desire for privacy may complicate the adoption of this method for Russian speakers.

Another method for empowering this group in a clinical setting might be helping them to put their experiences in context by exploring the systems that they are navigating and the special challenges they have had to overcome. This can be spoken about in a way that helps Russian-speaking clients to reflect upon their own resilience and competence in the face of these challenges, as well as the skills they have obtained that native-born non-immigrant clients may have not needed to obtain. This can be done through construction

of a narrative of their immigration experience, or other forms of autobiographical self-reflection, as has been shown effective with female Mexican immigrants (Ramirez & Monk, 2017).

Recommendations for future research

While this study accomplished its goal of illuminating how EL is experienced by Russian-speaking immigrants, further and more extensive qualitative studies of EL in a wider variety of Russian-speaking immigrants and immigrants from other cultural backgrounds would allow for more light to be shed on how immigrants experience EL in diverse occupational roles. Given the prominence of these White participants' descriptions of discrimination in the workplace, it would be particularly important to conduct further research that centers the experience of immigrants who do not present as White, to learn more about how racism and discrimination affects the daily performance of EL for immigrants.

Participant responses emphasized a sensitivity towards issues of trust and camaraderie in the workplace. This offers a fascinating avenue for future vocational and emotional labor research into how camaraderie and friendship affect work experiences, especially emotional labor experiences and work satisfaction, for immigrants and non-immigrants alike. While trust appears to be especially salient for Russian-speaking immigrants, future research can explore whether this is true for other immigrant groups, as well as how interpersonal trust can be fostered between colleagues of diverse cultural backgrounds.

Nearly all participants commented on the stress of switching from a culture with a direct, sometimes harsh, communication style to one where critique was indirect and

cushioned by praise. This suggests future research into exactly how such a communicative transition can be facilitated in the workplace, as well as the costs and benefits of each communication style across cultures. Several participants suggested that their responses to the indirect style of feedback was, at least initially, considerably slower than it would have been in their previous Russian work environments where they were told frankly when they were doing something wrong. Several also spoke about how U.S. supervisors' and bosses' gentler and more positive communication style felt more inspiring and less threatening. What exactly is the effect of this communication style on productivity and morale for immigrant employees? Future studies can explore this question further.

This study's findings suggest another avenue for future research: the study of acculturation processes through the lens of EL, analyzing the comparative outcomes for deep acting methods of acculturation versus surface acting methods. This could be done in the context of multicultural workplaces, or outside of work contexts. Mapping the effects of acculturative EL onto previous findings about EL at work might help further illuminate the ways that EL is culturally situated.

An additional observation emerged from the eclectic way that participants chose to fill out the demographic form. It was clear, both from the form and in conversation, that Russian-speaking immigrants have a very different understanding of ethnicity from Americans. Given this difference, future quantitative researchers should consider how they pose questions regarding ethnic identity when surveying this population, especially in studies that seek to use ethnicity as a variable to classify individuals from this group (Helms, 2007).

Recommendations for policy

This study demonstrates that emotional labor is a large factor in the daily experiences of immigrants at work, especially female immigrants. Given the ubiquity of emotional labor, it is incumbent upon fields that work with immigrants to familiarize themselves with its impacts. The field of counseling psychology, with its emphasis on multicultural competence, would do well to incorporate knowledge of EL into guidelines for training and practice. This recommendation can be extended to all mental healthcare professionals and paraprofessionals. Specific training on EL, its contribution to burnout, and how its effects vary by gender, intersectional identity factors, and cultural context, would help optimize mental healthcare practitioners' ability to respond to EL's negative effects.

Additionally, human resource and management professionals would do well to inform themselves on the dynamics of EL in workplaces, and how their burdens often disproportionately fall upon women and marginalized groups. Better information about EL would allow these human service fields to more skillfully address the experiences and needs of women and immigrant communities of all backgrounds.

Results from this study may inform future policy around Russian-speaking immigrants in US workplaces, in order to facilitate adjustment and well-being. Employers should create workplace policies and structures that correct for the unequal burdens of EL, while supporting those employees, such as women and other historically marginalized groups, who are known to be disproportionately affected by EL demands. Organizations employing Russian-speaking immigrants are recommended to attend to the cultural adaptation process that their immigrant employees are undergoing. Colleagues

should be discouraged from mocking foreign accents, and instead be encouraged to facilitate immigrant employees' attempts to be understood.

A specific person or group of people could be assigned as a supportive resource for immigrant employees, to whom they can direct questions and feel safe being vulnerable when they are confused or feel misunderstood. This person might be an immigrant who feels comfortably acculturated to the new environment, such as Annika described herself in this study, or it could be an individual with a background in acculturation psychology, and special training that sensitizes them to the issues common to new immigrants. Another important factor to recognize is that, even after many years, immigrants might still not feel fully connected to the culture of their host country and might feel that certain “blanks” (in Lana’s words) remain in their knowledge, enforcing a continued need to have a safe resource to consult for any lingering questions or misunderstandings.

Findings also indicate that Russian-speaking immigrants feel more comfortable and welcome in diverse communities where individuals are more accustomed to foreign accents, and there is less overt discrimination. While this finding appears obvious, it also points to ways that less diverse communities might be made more hospitable and open to immigrant newcomers. Familiarizing individuals with diverse ways of speaking English, through educational initiatives or activities that promote international communicative exchange (e.g. pen pals, video chat partnerships), would allow individuals even in relatively isolated communities to develop higher levels of comfort with non-native English speakers, and potentially decrease xenophobic discrimination.

Conclusion

This study expands the literature on EL by uniquely highlighting how interpersonal trust, social control and feelings of vulnerability impact the experience of EL for one specific immigrant population. These factors have not been as well-examined in previous work on the topic of EL. The use of in-depth qualitative data allowed for a nuanced portrait of how trust, control and safety intersect with emotional performance.

In addition, this study highlighted the way that gender and acculturation may intersect to create heavier EL burdens for female immigrants. Women in this study described struggling to gain credibility and authority in their work roles, needing to exert themselves to emote in the ways expected of them in the US, and needing to sideline their own careers in order to accommodate childcare and the careers of their husbands. An intersectional lens (Crenshaw, 1989) allows researchers and others who work with immigrant women to better understand the particular ways that this group are subordinated, due to both immigrant status and gendered interpersonal dynamics.

This study demonstrates the need for sensitive and specific policy, practice and research for Russian-speaking immigrants and all immigrant groups, in order to more fully illuminate their experiences in the workplace and create hospitable work environments in which they can optimally engage their skills. The first step in creating attentive, compassionate policies, practices, and research is to interrogate the assumption of cultural homogeneity, and instead replace it with a curiosity about cultural variation. Further qualitative studies of EL experiences with diverse immigrant groups could highlight how their experiences converge with those of the Russian-speaking immigrants in this study.

Further studies of the multicultural workplace could shed light on how gender affects these experiences. Intervention research could help discover ways of facilitating emotional and communication adaptation, and workplace camaraderie, in order to bolster Russian-speaking immigrants' feeling of being supported and not judged in their acclimatization to work in the US. It is recommended that fields providing human services to immigrant women familiarize themselves with the specific challenges that this group faces in acclimating to the US workplace. It is similarly recommended that mental healthcare workers familiarize themselves with the concept of emotional labor and its effects in different clinical populations. Finally, counseling psychologists and other mental healthcare providers can use the themes that proved especially salient to Russian-speaking immigrants as guidelines to formulate treatments of optimal relevance and effectiveness.

This research expands the awareness of how intercultural dynamics create unique pressures for immigrants at work, and specific pressures for immigrant women. While this is the first known study to investigate the EL experiences of Russian-speaking immigrants, it is far from the first qualitative study of EL. The results of this study affirm the findings of Mesquita & Delvaux (2013), that EL costs more effort for individuals who experience a larger gap between the everyday emotion regulation strategies of their culture and the emotional expectations of their workplace. The results add new dimensions to the emotional tax of vigilance against discrimination paid by women and minorities in the workplace (Travis & Thorpe-Moscon, 2018), by highlighting the specifics of the emotional tax paid by immigrant workers.

Russian-speaking immigrants in this study derived a great sense of self-efficacy and satisfaction from their US careers and were enthusiastic contributors to the workplace. Results suggest that Russian-speaking immigrants thrive in environments that affirm their talents and offer them challenges and responsibilities commensurate with their skills. This study highlights the importance of appropriate post-migration employment to promote positive identity and self-esteem.

Finally, an in-depth qualitative exploration of Russian-speaking immigrant experiences of EL was thus shown to be an important methodological approach, as it highlighted the ways that this group defied traditional cultural categories and the varied and highly relational adaptation processes this group underwent at work. Forced-choice survey options could not have captured the unique combination of individualism, collectivism, relationality and independence that allowed this group to thrive. More qualitative work of this kind could potentially illuminate many other underexamined experiences of immigrants in the workplace.

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APPENDIX A: Consent Form

University of Miami Consent to Participate in Research

Title of study: Immigrants at Work

Investigator: Alexandra Lane, Debbiesiu Lee

Introduction and Purpose

You are being invited to join a research study.

The purpose of this study is to understand your experiences as a person who has immigrated as an adult to the United States and works at a job that involves a lot of contact with people.

If you agree to participate in this research, you will be asked questions about your life, your work, and how you think and feel about your experiences at work. This interview will take from one to two hours to complete. The interview will be audio recorded with your permission. After the interview is written down, the recordings will be destroyed.

Risk/ Benefit

The risks of this research is minimal. Some of the questions in the interview might make you feel uncomfortable or upset. You do not have to answer any of the questions you do not want to answer.

There is no direct benefit to you if you take part in this study. We hope this research will help us better understand the experiences of people like you who have immigrated as adults and are currently working in roles that involve interpersonal contact.

Confidentiality

As with all research, there is a chance that confidentiality could be compromised. To minimize the risks to confidentiality, we will store all data on password protected and secured servers. After you have participated, all identifying information will be deleted and replaced by a pseudonym, or “fake name.” Information that identifies you will be included with the information; however a link to your identity will be maintained separate from the information.

When the research is completed, the investigator will save the data for possible use in future research done by myself/us or others for up to 3 years after the study is over. The same measures described above will be taken to protect confidentiality of this study data.

Individuals from the University of Miami who oversee research may access your data during audits or other monitoring activities.

Compensation

To thank you for participating in this study, you will receive a \$20 Amazon gift card that will be emailed to you within 4 weeks after you complete the interview.

Rights

Participation in research is completely voluntary. You are free to decline to take part in the project. You can decline to answer any questions and you can stop taking part in the project at any time. Whether or not you choose to participate, or answer any question, or stop participating in the project, there will be no penalty to you or loss of benefits to which you are otherwise entitled.

Questions

If you have any questions about this research, please feel free to contact Alexandra Lane (786-897-7224 or aal58@miami.edu), who is under the supervision of Dr. Debbiesiu Lee (debbiesiu@miami.edu).

If you have any questions about your rights or treatment as a research participant in this study, please contact the University of Miami Human Subjects Research Office at 305-243-3195 or hsro@med.miami.edu.

If you agree to take part in the research and allow the interview to be recorded, please keep a copy of this form for future reference.

APPENDIX B: Recruitment Flyer

Hello,

My name is Ali Lane and I am a 5th year PhD candidate in counseling psychology at the University of Miami. For my dissertation, I am exploring the experiences of Russian-speaking immigrants who have immigrated as adults and are now living and working in the United States. I am specifically interested in how immigrants have adapted socially to working with Americans on a daily basis. Because I am from Russian-Jewish heritage, though a few generations back, I am particularly interested in how the more recent wave of Russian speaking immigrants have adapted to life in the U.S. Through this project, I hope to expand the information available on this topic. I'm interested in your story of adapting, and I hope you will share it with me.

Our conversation would take place over Zoom video conferencing software, and would take about an hour. As a token of gratitude for your participation, I would send you a \$20 credit on Amazon.

If you immigrated from one of the former republics of the Former Soviet Union as an adult (18+) and have now or have in the past had a job that involves interacting with other people I would be interested in speaking with you.

Would you be interested in participating in this study? Please let me know if you have any questions or concerns.

Thank you!

Ali Lane (aal58@miami.edu)

APPENDIX C: Interview Guide

Introduction:

Thank you for agreeing to speak with me. I'm a Ph.D. student at the University of Miami, and I'm interested in the experiences of people like you, Russian speakers who have immigrated from a different country and now live and work in the United States. I'm specifically interested in how you've adapted to working with people from the US. I was hoping that you'd be willing to talk with me about these experiences.

Our conversation will take from one to two hours. If you grant me permission, I'd like to audio-record our conversation. The recording will remain confidential and will be helpful to me in making sure that I don't forget any important information you share with me. The recording will be transcribed for later analysis. Names and identifying details will not be used. All names will be replaced with pseudonyms. Do you have a preferred pseudonym?

If you aren't comfortable answering a question, you don't have to answer. You can end our conversation at any time. If you decide you don't want me to use our conversation in this project, you can withdraw your consent at any time.

After I write about this and the other interviews I conduct, I would also like to come back to you with what I write, to see if it seems accurate to you. You are the expert on this experience, and I would appreciate your point of view on the results of this research. Would you be comfortable doing that?

Background

Living

How would you describe your cultural/ethnic identity?

How long have you lived in the US?

Do you live among many Russian people/people who share your background?

Are you connected to many Russian [/your background] people and/or Russian [your] culture?

Do you have many friends who share your background? / Are most of your friends Russian?

Working

How long have you worked at your current job?

Do you work among many Russian people/people who share your background?

What drew you to this work?

Is this work similar to what you did in Russia/[country of origin]?

Central questions:

Emotional labor

[Ask questions chronologically for each of the following:

- 1. The first job you had in the US.**
- 2. Most memorable job in the US.**
- 3. Current position]**
 - What type of feelings do/did you think you are/were expected to have/express in this job?
 - Specify prompts to specific work roles [e.g. *with clients, with coworkers, in meetings, with superiors, with boss*]
 - Ask for ***specific example*** of feelings expectation (can you think of one time when that happened? / When was the last time that happened?)
 - How does/did your [work organization] expect you to behave?
 - Specify prompts to specific work roles [e.g. *with clients, with coworkers, in meetings, with superiors, with boss*]
 - Ask for ***specific example*** of behavior expectation (can you think of one time when that happened? / When was the last time that happened?)

- Are there times when you don't/didn't have those feelings/don't feel like expressing that at work?
 - Ask for *specific example* of when you didn't feel like it (can you think of one time when that happened? / When was the last time that happened?)

Emotional labor strategies

- How do/did you get yourself to act the way you were expected to?
 - Ask for a *specific example* (can you think of one time when that happened? / When was the last time that happened?)
- Do you ever find the need to [produce a given feeling/emotional response] at work when you don't feel that way? (e.g. smile when you don't feel like it)
 - How do/did you manage to do that?
 - Ask for a *specific example* (can you think of one time when that happened? / When was the last time that happened?)

Acculturation & emotion

- How is the way you act at work different from how you act at home?
 - Ask for a *specific example* of difference (can you think of one time when you acted very differently than you would at home? / When was the last time you remember doing that?)
- How is the way you act at work here in the US different from how you might have acted at work in Russia/[country of origin]?

- Ask for a *specific example* of difference (can you think of one time when you acted very differently in [country of origin] than you would at work here? / When was the last time you remember doing that?)
- How is the way you act at work here in the US different from the way you acted at home in [your country of origin]?
 - Ask for a *specific example* of difference (can you think of one time when you acted very differently at home in [country of origin] than you would at work here? / When was the last time you remember doing that?)
- How would you compare the way that [boss/supervisor/colleague/client] act here and in [your country of origin]?
 - Ask for a *specific example* of difference (can you think of one time when a [boss/supervisor/client] acted very differently in [country of origin] than they would here?)
- How do you think you've adapted to working here, given those differences?
 - Ask for a *specific example* of adaptation (can you think of a time when you did [adaptation mentioned]?/ When was the last time you remember doing [adaptation mentioned]?)

APPENDIX D: Demographic Form

Gender: _____

Age: _____

Race: _____

Ethnicity: _____

Country of origin: _____

How long have you lived in the US? _____

What is your current job title? _____

What type of work did you do prior to coming to the US? _____
